

The Amphibious Imperative

Chronophagy, Kenotic Disobedience, and the Teratological Humanism of Guillermo del Toro

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the cinematic, televisual, and literary corpus of Guillermo del Toro, from *Cronos* (1993) to *Frankenstein* (2025), constitutes a coherent philosophical system rather than a sequence of genre exercises unified by a personal iconography. I name this system *teratological humanism*: a normative account of the human in which dignity is grounded neither in rational nature (Pico, Kant) nor in species membership, but in a specific refusal, enacted most purely by monsters, children, ghosts, and the women who recognise them. The refusal is directed against what I term *chronophagy*, the political-theological operation by which a subject, unable to accept his own finitude, converts mortality into the consumption of the time, bodies, and futures of others. Its mythic prototype is Kronos devouring his children to forestall succession; its historical avatars in del Toro are the fascist father (Vidal, the Podestà, the Thule occultists of *Hellboy*), the capitalist immortal (de la Guardia, Eldritch Palmer, Harlander, Ezra Grindle), the Promethean creator (Victor Frankenstein, Damaskinos), and the Saturnine sister (Lucille Sharpe); its emblem is clockwork, the mechanisation of time.

Against chronophagy the corpus opposes an *amphibious* counter-order, taking the term from Sir Thomas Browne's description of man as the creature disposed to live "in divided and distinguished worlds". Its characteristic ethical act is *kenotic disobedience*: the self-emptying renunciation of immortality, the refusal of every command that requires the sacrifice of the vulnerable, and the formation of elective kinship in place of patronymic lineage. Reconstructing the genealogy of these ideas through Hesiod, Goya, heterodox Catholic theology, the Mexican baroque, the Romantic circle of 1816, Lovecraft, and the fairy-tale tradition, the study places del Toro in sustained comparison with two intellectual lineages: a feminist genealogy running from Wollstonecraft, Sor Juana, and Mary Shelley through Carter, Irigaray, Kristeva, Cixous, Haraway, Federici, Anzaldúa, Butler, and Ahmed; and a humanist genealogy running from Pico, Montaigne, and Browne through Kant, Unamuno, Weil, Arendt, Levinas, Camus, and Nussbaum.

The dissertation advances six principal claims. First, the Pale Man of *Pan's Labyrinth*, who sees only through the palms that seize, allegorises conceptual grasping (*Begriff*, from *greifen*), against which del Toro develops a haptic ethics of the caress. Second, Ofelia's final trial inverts the *Akedah* and thereby

Kierkegaard's teleological suspension of the ethical: faith becomes fidelity to the vulnerable against the divine command. Third, *The Shape of Water* rewrites Lovecraft's "The Shadow over Innsmouth" and Carter's "The Tiger's Bride" into a xenophilic theology of the amphibious beloved. Fourth, *Frankenstein* (2025) relocates femicide from the monster to the maker and moves the Romantic myth from Mary Shelley's *Modern Prometheus* toward Percy Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound*, in which forgiveness, not vengeance, breaks the theogonic cycle of paternal violence. Fifth, del Toro's ghosts are testimonial rather than vindictive, constituting a feminist counter-archive of the ungrieved. Sixth, these strands converge in a categorical maxim, the *Amphibious Imperative*, which I formulate in four parts and situate between classical humanism and contemporary posthumanism as an answer to Foucault's prophecy that man would be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea.

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Introduction

The Clockwork Insect and the Axolotl

Et mundus transit, et concupiscentia eius.

1 John 2:17

I. *Two Emblems*

Del Toro's first feature opens on an object that already contains his entire cosmology. The Cronos device, a gilded scarab fashioned by a sixteenth-century alchemist fleeing the Inquisition to Veracruz, conceals within its clockwork chamber a living insect that, once the device has fastened its legs into the bearer's flesh, filters his blood and returns it rejuvenated. It is an apparatus of time that feeds on life, and it is hidden, for four centuries, inside the hollow statue of an archangel. Mechanism, insect, blood, and sanctity are fused in a single prop. Fifteen years after *Cronos*, Corpus Christi College, Cambridge, unveiled a public clock surmounted by a mechanical locust, the "Chronophage", which appears to devour each passing second above the Johannine inscription that serves as this Introduction's epigraph. The convergence is not influence but structure: the modern imagination, confronting time, repeatedly reaches for the image of a clockwork insect that eats, under the sign of the Body of Christ.

The second emblem is Mexican and aquatic. The axolotl, the neotenic salamander of the lake system of Xochimilco, bears the name of Xolotl, the Mexica god of twins, deformity, lightning, and the passage of the dead. In the account preserved in Sahagún's *Florentine Codex*, when the gods gathered at Teotihuacan resolved to die so that the Fifth Sun might move, Xolotl wept and fled, hiding first as a doubled maize stalk, then as a doubled maguey, and finally in the water as an axolotl, where he was caught and killed. The god of monstrous births is the god who would not consent to be sacrificed, and his last refuge was amphibious existence: a creature that never completes its metamorphosis, that regenerates severed limbs, and that lives between the larval and the adult, the aquatic and the terrestrial.

Between the devouring clock and the fleeing amphibian lies the moral universe of del Toro's work. The first emblem names what his films indict; the second names what they defend. This dissertation is an attempt to articulate the logic connecting them with the rigour the films themselves deserve.

II. *The State of the Question and Its Three Impasses*

Scholarship on del Toro has grown substantially since *Pan's Labyrinth* (2006), yet it remains organised around three impasses. The first is auteurist bifurcation: the habit of dividing the corpus into "personal" Spanish-language films (*Cronos*, *The Devil's Backbone*, *Pan's Labyrinth*) and "commercial" English-language studio productions (*Mimic*, *Blade II*, the *Hellboy* films, *Pacific Rim*). Deborah Shaw's study of the "three amigos" (2013) and the collection edited by Ann Davies, Shaw, and Dolores Tierney (2014) rightly reframe this division through transnational cinema studies, but even there the oscillation tends to be treated as an industrial condition rather than a philosophical one. I argue that the oscillation is itself amphibious and therefore meaningful: del Toro's career enacts at the level of production the double residence his monsters enact at the level of ontology.

The second impasse is sentimental inversion, the reading that reduces the corpus to the proposition that monsters are good and humans bad. The formula is not false so much as structurally inadequate. Del Toro's monsters are not uniformly benign: the Amphibian Man eats a cat, the Creature of 2025 kills, the Faun lies or at least withholds, Prince Nuada would exterminate humanity. Nor are his humans uniformly vicious: Dr. Ferreiro, Hoffstetler, Professor Broom, and Geppetto are human and kenotic. The operative distinction does not track the line between species. It tracks the line between chronophagy and its refusal, a line that runs through humans and monsters alike.

The third impasse is disciplinary fragmentation. Memory studies have read the Spanish Civil War films through Spain's politics of forgetting (Labanyi 2000); fairy-tale studies have read *Pan's Labyrinth* and *Pinocchio* as revisionist *Märchen* (Zipes 2011); horror and genre studies have catalogued the Lovecraftian and Universal inheritances; Keith McDonald and Roger Clark (2014) have proposed alchemy as a unifying master-trope. Each reading is partial in a precise sense: it illuminates one panel while leaving unexplained why the same structure recurs across fascist Spain, Cold War Baltimore, Edwardian Cumberland, Depression-era carnivals, Mussolini's Italy, and the Arctic of the 1850s.

III. *Thesis*

The central claim of this dissertation is that del Toro's corpus dramatises a single cosmological conflict between Saturn and the Newborn, and that from this conflict a complete ethics can be derived. I develop it through five interlocking concepts.

Chronophagy names the regime by which the dread of death is converted into the devouring of others' time. It has three features: it is temporal, in that it arrests succession and forbids the future to arrive; it is economic, in that it extracts the lifetime of children, women, workers, nature, and monsters as resource; and it is theological, in that it counterfeits eternity as private property.

The amphibium names the ontological condition of beings who inhabit divided worlds: living and dead, human and animal, flesh and wood, history and fantasy. Its exemplars are the monster, the ghost, the child, and the woman who recognises the monster because she is herself partly exiled from the Saturnine order.

Kenotic disobedience names the characteristic ethical act of the amphibious: a refusal, modelled on the self-emptying of Philippians 2:7, in which immortality is renounced, sacrificial commands are disobeyed, and the cycle of paternal violence is broken by forgiveness rather than by filial revolt.

The amphibious commons names the form of community this act generates: kinship elected rather than inherited, founded on shared vulnerability rather than shared blood, name, nation, or species.

The Amphibious Imperative names the categorical maxim into which these concepts condense, formulated in the Conclusion in deliberate counterpoint to Kant's formula of humanity.

Taken together, these concepts constitute *teratological humanism*. It is humanist because it retains, against posthumanist dissolution, a strong normative claim about what it means to be human. It is teratological because it locates the paradigm of that humanity in the monster.

IV. *Method*

Three methodological commitments govern what follows. The first is that films can philosophise, a position defended in different idioms by Stanley Cavell,

Gilles Deleuze, and Stephen Mulhall. Del Toro's thinking happens chiefly in mise-en-scène: in colour coding (warm ambers against cold cyans in *Pan's Labyrinth*, the oppressive teal of the "future" in *The Shape of Water*, the arterial reds of *Crimson Peak*), in recurring props (clocks, jars, insects, keys, shoes), and in architecture conceived as anatomy. Production design is, for this director, a mode of metaphysical argument.

The second commitment is to read del Toro's recurring performers as a moral typology. Federico Luppi plays the gentle Republican humanist across *Cronos*, *The Devil's Backbone*, and *Pan's Labyrinth*, where he becomes the King of the underworld. David Bradley carries the figure of the kenotic elder from Abraham Setrakian in *The Strain* through the voice of Geppetto to the blind teacher of *Frankenstein*. Christoph Waltz embodies the exploitative patron as both Count Volpe and Harlander. Luke Goss plays two patricidal princes, Nomak and Nuada, whose grievances are righteous and whose means are Saturnine. Doug Jones lends his body to the Faun, the Pale Man, Abe Sapien, the Angel of Death, and the Amphibian Man. The repertory is a grammar.

The third commitment is genealogical and comparative. I trace ideas to their originators, then set del Toro beside feminist and humanist texts that were not his sources but that think the same problems, and finally propose a synthesis that none of the parties would have arrived at alone. Where the analysis is speculative, I have tried to say so; where it reconstructs del Toro's own statements, I paraphrase public interviews and speeches rather than relying on unverifiable anecdote. Classical, scriptural, and early modern texts are cited by conventional division; modern works by author and date.

V. *Corpus*

The primary corpus comprises thirteen features: *Cronos* (1993), *Mimic* (1997), *The Devil's Backbone* (2001), *Blade II* (2002), *Hellboy* (2004), *Pan's Labyrinth* (2006), *Hellboy II: The Golden Army* (2008), *Pacific Rim* (2013), *Crimson Peak* (2015), *The Shape of Water* (2017), *Nightmare Alley* (2021), *Guillermo del Toro's Pinocchio* (2022, co-directed with Mark Gustafson), and *Frankenstein* (2025). It also includes *The Strain* novels and series written with Chuck Hogan, *Trollhunters*, the anthology *Cabinet of Curiosities* (2022), the novelisations co-written with Daniel Kraus and Cornelia Funke, and the published notebooks.

Productions he shepherded for other directors, notably *The Orphanage* (2007) and *Mama* (2013), are treated as satellite texts.

VI. *Architecture of the Argument*

Chapter One defines chronophagy through the iconography of Saturn and anatomises its four figures, its clockwork, its armoured body, and its grasping hand. Chapter Two reads del Toro's heterodox Catholicism through the vampire as inverted Eucharist and the monster as kenotic god. Chapter Three constructs the ontology of the amphibium from Renaissance humanist teratology through Lovecraft, Haraway, and Anzaldúa. Chapter Four reads *The Devil's Backbone*, *Pan's Labyrinth*, and *Pinocchio* as an anti-fascist triptych whose central figure is the disobedient child. Chapter Five reads the ghosts of *The Devil's Backbone*, *Crimson Peak*, and *Nightmare Alley* as a feminist spectral archive. Chapter Six reads *The Shape of Water* as the culmination of the beast-bridegroom tradition and its feminist reversal. Chapter Seven reads *Frankenstein* (2025) as the summa of the corpus. Chapter Eight reads *Hellboy* and *Pacific Rim* as essays on elective kinship. The Conclusion formulates the Amphibious Imperative and assesses its limits.



Chapter One

Saturn's Table

Chronophagy as Political Theology

Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks.

Marx, *Capital*, vol. 1, ch. 10, trans. Moore and Aveling, 1887

1.1 *Kronos, Chronos, and the Devouring Father*

Hesiod's *Theogony* records a cosmos founded on paternal fear. Ouranos imprisons his children in the body of Gaia; Kronos castrates him and, warned that a son will overthrow him in turn, swallows each child Rhea bears, until she substitutes a swaddled stone and saves Zeus, who forces his father to disgorge his siblings and inaugurates the Olympian order. The myth is a cycle: each sovereign secures his reign by consuming or suppressing his succession, and each is overthrown by the succession he failed to consume. Late antique and Renaissance mythography compounded the horror by conflating Kronos with Chronos, Time. Panofsky's study of "Father Time" (1939) traces how the scythe-bearing devourer of the Renaissance fused the Titan who eats his children with the time that eats all things, while Klibansky, Panofsky, and Saxl (1964) showed how the same planet governed melancholy, genius, and the cold, dry temperament of those who hoard.

The Spanish visual unconscious received this fusion in its most terrible form in Goya's *Saturn Devouring His Son*, painted on the walls of the Quinta del Sordo around 1820 to 1823. Goya's Saturn is not a sovereign calmly securing his throne; he is a starving madman whose eyes bulge with terror at his own act. Del Toro's camera returns to this image with programmatic insistence. The title of his first feature fuses Kronos and Chronos in a single word. The banquet hall of the Pale Man in *Pan's Labyrinth* is frescoed with scenes of a pallid giant devouring children, beneath which lies a heap of children's shoes. The image recalls the mounds of shoes that the SS took from the Jews and others it murdered at Auschwitz-Birkenau, Majdanek, and the other Nazi extermination camps, children's shoes among them, which were found and photographed when the Soviet army reached the camps. Captain Vidal's pocket watch, the Golden Army's clockwork legions, and the hourglasses of *Pinocchio* extend the image from the body that eats to the mechanism that measures. Saturn is the presiding deity of del Toro's villainy because he is the god in whom the fear of death and the hunger for others become one appetite.

1.2 *Defining Chronophagy*

I define chronophagy as the conversion of one's own mortality into another's consumption. The chronophage is not simply cruel or greedy; he is a subject who has refused finitude and who, because finitude cannot actually be refused, displaces it onto those whose time he can appropriate. Three structural features follow. Temporally, chronophagy forbids succession: the future, embodied in the child, must not arrive except as the chronophage's own extension. Economically, it extracts: the lifetime of others becomes a resource to be drawn down, which is why Marx's vampire is not a metaphor laid over capital but the precise image of a social form that lives by absorbing living labour-time. Theologically, it counterfeits eternity, privatising the promise of deathlessness that the Christian tradition located in a God who gives his life rather than takes it.

This definition allows the analysis to pass beneath the surface variety of del Toro's antagonists to the structure they share. Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973) supplies the existential premise: human beings construct "immortality projects" to escape the knowledge of their creatureliness, and in *Escape from Evil* (1975) Becker argued that the most destructive of these projects are those that purchase the self's survival with another's sacrifice. Unamuno had already named the root a generation earlier, in *Del sentimiento trágico de la vida* (1913), as *el hambre de inmortalidad*, the hunger for immortality that he considered the very substance of the human. Del Toro's corpus may be read as a sustained distinction between two ways of bearing that hunger: as an agonic longing that remains within one's own breast, which is Unamuno's way and the way of del Toro's heroes; or as an appetite turned outward onto the bodies of others, which is Saturn's way.

1.3 *The Four Figures of Saturn*

The fascist father. Captain Vidal is the corpus's purest chronophage. His relation to time is liturgical: he winds, consults, and caresses the watch that, according to a legend he publicly denies, his father smashed at the moment of his death so that his son would know how a brave man dies. His relation to the future is proprietary: he wants a son to inherit his name, and he instructs Dr. Ferreiro that, should he have to choose, the child is to be saved rather than the

mother. Carmen's body is thereby reduced to a vessel for patrilineal transmission. His violence against other men's sons is the reverse face of this dynastic hunger: early in the film he beats a young farmer to death with a bottle and shoots the young man's father, on a groundless suspicion that they are aiding the guerrillas, then finds in their bag the rabbits they had been hunting; later he personally tortures a captured guerrilla. Klaus Theweleit's *Männerphantasien* (1977–78) supplies the psychic portrait: the Freikorps officer armours his body against everything fluid, female, and mass-like, and experiences social disorder as a flood that threatens his hardened contours. Theweleit drew that portrait from the novels and memoirs of men who fought in the Freikorps between 1918 and 1923, texts that return again and again to the killing of working-class and communist women, the "rifle-women" (Flintenweiber) of their fantasies, as the act that restores the armoured self. The fantasy had a historical referent: Freikorps officers murdered Rosa Luxemburg in Berlin in January 1919 and threw her body into the Landwehr Canal. Vidal's ritual shaving, his polished boots, his straight-lined world of mill, stable, and storeroom are Theweleit's armour made architecture. The Podestà of *Pinocchio*, who drills his son for war and covets a wooden boy who cannot die because he would make the perfect soldier, and the Thule occultists of *Hellboy*, whose assassin Kroenen runs on clockwork and dust rather than blood, extend the type from Spain to Italy and Germany.

The capitalist immortal. Dieter de la Guardia, the dying industrialist of *Cronos*, inhabits a sealed, sterile chamber surrounded by the angel statues he has accumulated in his decades-long search for the device. Eldritch Palmer in *The Strain* trades the city of New York for the Master's promise of eternal life. Harlander in *Frankenstein* is an arms manufacturer whose patronage of Victor's research is revealed as a scheme for his own corporeal survival. Ezra Grindle in *Nightmare Alley* attempts to purchase absolution from the ghost of Dorrie, a young woman who died after he forced her to undergo an abortion. Count Volpe in *Pinocchio* contracts a child's labour and pockets the proceeds. Franco Moretti's "The Dialectic of Fear" (1982) argued that nineteenth-century horror produced two complementary monsters: Dracula, the monopolist who accumulates life, and Frankenstein's creature, the dispossessed proletarian assembled from the parts of the poor. Del Toro's capitalists occupy Dracula's position without his aristocratic glamour, and his monsters occupy the creature's. The geek of *Nightmare Alley*, a destitute drinker whom the carnival's owner, Clem

Hoately, hires with the promise of temporary work and then keeps dependent with opium-laced liquor until he will bite the heads off live chickens for paying crowds, is the human proletarian reduced, by the logic Moretti identified, to the condition of the monster.

The Promethean creator. Victor Frankenstein's desire to abolish death, Damaskinos's engineering of a superior vampire strain in *Blade II*, and the alchemist Fulcanelli's device in *Cronos* share a structure: creation undertaken for the creator's perpetuation rather than the creature's flourishing. Anne K. Mellor (1988) read Shelley's novel as a critique of exactly this, of a masculine science that usurps female reproduction and then abandons its offspring. Del Toro adds the political economy Shelley left implicit: Victor's work is underwritten by munitions money, and Damaskinos's by an aristocratic eugenic project. *Mimic* offers the instructive counter-case of Susan Tyler, the entomologist who engineers the Judas Breed to save children from an epidemic and then, when the species survives its designed sterility and evolves, descends into the tunnels to take responsibility for what she made. The female Prometheus of 1997 does what the male Prometheus of 2025 learns only at the hour of his death.

The Saturnine sister. Lucille Sharpe of *Crimson Peak* is the corpus's most sustained exploration of chronophagy in a feminine register. She murders a succession of brides for their fortunes, which fund her brother's clay-extracting machine and the preservation of a decaying ancestral house; she has killed her own mother; and her bond with Thomas is incestuous. Lévi-Strauss (1949) argued that the incest prohibition is the hinge between nature and culture because it compels exogamy, the exchange that opens a group to strangers and therefore to history. Lucille's incest is chronophagy as endogamous closure: a refusal of the stranger, the future, and time itself, sustained by the literal consumption of women who enter the house from outside. Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine (1993) captures her abjection, but a feminist reading must add that Lucille is produced by the house, an aristocratic and patriarchal machine whose violence she has internalised. She tells Edith that their father broke their mother's leg, and their mother in turn beat Lucille and locked both children away in the attic: the violence passes from husband to wife and from mother to children before Lucille turns it outward. She is Saturn's daughter before she is Saturn.

1.4 *Clockwork: The Mechanisation of Time*

Lewis Mumford's *Technics and Civilization* (1934) proposed that the clock, not the steam engine, was the key machine of the industrial age, because it dissociated time from human events and made it a measurable, saleable quantity. E. P. Thompson (1967) documented the imposition of clock discipline on labouring populations; Carolyn Merchant's *The Death of Nature* (1980) traced how a mechanistic cosmology displaced the organic, feminised nature of earlier European thought. Del Toro's clockwork condenses all three arguments. The Cronos device imprisons a living insect inside gears; Kroenen's heart is wound with a key; the Golden Army is an infinitely reassembling clockwork legion, the fascist fantasy of soldiers who do not die. In *Pan's Labyrinth*, the Faun gives Ofelia an hourglass for her descent into the Pale Man's lair, setting fairy-tale time against Vidal's watch. In *Pinocchio*, Death presides over hourglasses whose sand runs longer each time the wooden boy returns from the dead, so that the instrument of measurement becomes an instrument of mortality accepted rather than mortality controlled.

Against clockwork, del Toro sets insect time. Insects in this corpus are enslaved in *Cronos*, engineered and self-liberating in *Mimic*, psychopomps in *Pan's Labyrinth*, predators in Lucille's speech about moths that feed on butterflies, and objects of non-possessive attention for the Elizabeth of *Frankenstein*. What unites them is metamorphosis, the Ovidian truth that a living thing becomes other in time. Clockwork repeats; insects transform. The most compressed formulation comes in *The Devil's Backbone*, whose narration defines a ghost as, among other things, *un insecto atrapado en ámbar*, an insect trapped in amber. The ghost is the victim of chronophagy: a being whose metamorphosis was arrested by violence and whose time has been stopped, suspended, and preserved for an observer. Kafka's Gregor Samsa, the son whose labour has supported his family and who is discarded once he becomes vermin, is the literary ancestor of this figure, and his family's relief at his death is a domestic chronophagy that del Toro's films refuse to share.

1.5 *The Saturnine Body*

Chronophagy has a corresponding somatics. The Saturnine body is sealed, armoured, hygienic, and dry. Mikhail Bakhtin (1965) contrasted the classical

body, closed and finished, with the grotesque body of carnival, open at every orifice and continuous with the world. Mary Douglas (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place and showed that purity rules police the boundaries of social order. Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) located in abjection the expulsion by which the subject secures its "clean and proper" self, where *le propre* signifies both cleanliness and property. Martha Nussbaum's *Hiding from Humanity* (2004) added the political consequence: disgust is a projection of our own animality and mortality onto subordinated groups, who are then treated as contaminants.

Del Toro's chronophages are anatomised precisely along these lines. Vidal shaves with ritual care; de la Guardia lives in a hermetic room; Richard Strickland in *The Shape of Water* lectures on the masculinity of washing one's hands before rather than after urinating and pathologises the creature, Zelda, and Giles in the same register of disgust. Yet the armour invariably conceals rot. Strickland's reattached fingers blacken and putrefy until he tears them off; de la Guardia's body is decomposing in its clean room; Harlander is dying of syphilis; Vidal's mouth, slit open by Mercedes's kitchen knife, must be sewn shut by his own hand. The wound is significant: Saturn's organ is the mouth, and del Toro's women and monsters repeatedly attack the devouring mouth and the grasping hand. The armoured body is not the opposite of corruption but its disguise, and the films' grotesque bodies, open and leaking and soft, are the bodies of those who have nothing to hide.

1.6 *The Grasping Hand and the Caress*

The Pale Man is del Toro's most original contribution to the iconography of evil, and his anatomy contains an argument. He has no eyes in his face; his eyes sit in the palms of his hands, so that he can see only what he reaches for. He perceives by seizing. German philosophy has a word for this structure. *Begriff*, concept, derives from *begreifen*, to grasp, and in Hegel the concept is the movement by which thought takes hold of its object and makes it its own. Adorno and Horkheimer's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1947) indicted the Enlightenment for reducing reason to an instrument of domination, and Adorno's *Negative Dialectics* (1966) argued that identity thinking violates the nonidentical by subsuming it under concepts that grasp. The Pale Man is identity thinking given a body: an epistemology in which to know is to seize and to seize is to devour.

The hand has a philosophical history that sharpens this reading. Heidegger, in the lectures published as *Was heißt Denken?* (1954), claimed that thinking is a kind of handicraft and that only the human being has a hand in the proper sense, the ape possessing merely organs for grasping. Derrida's "Geschlecht II: Heidegger's Hand" (1987) dismantled this claim as an anthropocentric decree that assigned grasping to animals and technology while reserving giving and thinking for Dasein. Del Toro reverses Heidegger's distribution: it is the fascist whose hand grasps, and the monster whose hand gives. Hellboy's stone Right Hand of Doom, destined to turn the key of apocalypse, cradles an infant. The Amphibian Man bites off the fingers with which Strickland wields his cattle prod. Ofelia's chalk draws doors in walls. Geppetto's carving hand converts grief into a child.

The positive term is supplied by Levinas, whose *Totality and Infinity* (1961) describes the caress as a touch that seizes upon nothing and solicits what ceaselessly escapes its form. That last phrase could stand as an epigraph to *The Shape of Water*, whose title names a substance that has no shape of its own. Del Toro's cinema thus articulates what I call a haptic ethics, distributed across three gestures: the grasp, which possesses; the caress, which approaches without appropriating; and the making hand, which gives form as gift. His notorious fidelity to prosthetics, animatronics, and stop-motion, his public insistence that animation is cinema rather than a genre, is the production-level expression of the same ethics: a cinema made by hands that shape rather than seize.



Chapter Two

The Inverted Eucharist

Vampirism, Kenosis, and the Creaturely Catholicism of the Monster

Only be sure that thou eat not the blood: for the blood is the life.

Deuteronomy 12:23

Whoso eateth my flesh, and drinketh my blood, hath eternal life.

John 6:54

2.1 *A Recovering Catholic in the Mexican Baroque*

Del Toro has repeatedly described himself as a lapsed or recovering Catholic formed by a devout grandmother in Guadalajara, and he has spoken of his childhood encounter with Boris Karloff's Creature in the vocabulary of conversion. These biographical facts matter less than the visual and theological grammar they transmitted. Mexican colonial Catholicism is a baroque of the wounded body: polychrome Christs with glass eyes, human hair, and wounds rendered in lacquered crimson; and *ex-votos*, small votive paintings on tin in which a miraculous intervention erupts into an ordinary scene of accident or illness. The *ex-voto* is the formal ancestor of del Toro's fantastic. It does not locate the marvellous in a separate realm; it shows the sacred breaking into a kitchen, a road, a sickbed. Frida Kahlo appropriated the same form for a feminist iconography of the injured female body, and her example establishes that the Mexican votive tradition could already serve as a vehicle for a counter-theology of suffering.

Two Latin American theorists of the baroque supply the political frame. José Lezama Lima (1957) called the American baroque an *arte de la contraconquista*, an art of counter-conquest in which colonised subjects turned the conqueror's forms against him through proliferating excess. Bolívar Echeverría (1998) identified a "baroque ethos" as one of four ways of inhabiting capitalist modernity: neither affirming nor rejecting its order outright, but theatricalising it until its claims to necessity become visible as artifice. Del Toro's maximalism, his densely layered production design and his insistence on handcrafted surfaces within industrial genres, is baroque in exactly this sense. It is a mode of surviving inside Hollywood by overloading its forms with a heterodox Mexican-Catholic content they were not designed to carry.

Octavio Paz's *El laberinto de la soledad* (1950) argued that the Mexican relation to death is one of intimacy, irony, and festivity, and warned that this intimacy can curdle into indifference. Del Toro's films practise intimacy without indifference. The *ofrenda* of the Day of the Dead, a table on which the living set food for the dead, is the precise inverse of Saturn's table, at which the old devour the young. The Pale Man's banquet, laid with food that the living are forbidden to eat, is an anti-*ofrenda*: a feast that traps rather than nourishes, presided over by a devourer rather than offered to the departed.

2.2 *The Blood Is the Life: Vampirism as Anti-Communion*

The Eucharist and the vampire share a single proposition, that blood confers eternal life, and differ only in its direction. In the Eucharist, a god gives his blood so that others may live; in vampirism, a mortal takes others' blood so that he need not die. Del Toro's vampire cycle is a sustained meditation on this inversion.

Cronos names its protagonist Jesús Gris and builds his passion with liturgical precision. The device pierces his flesh like stigmata. At a New Year's Eve party he kneels on the floor of a bathroom to lick a stranger's nosebleed from the tiles, a scene of abjection staged as a parody of communion. Beaten and killed by de la Guardia's nephew, he is embalmed with sutured face and rises from his coffin before cremation, finding refuge in his granddaughter Aurora's toy chest, which becomes his sepulchre. The child shelters the vampire, reversing the predatory relation the genre presumes. The climax is a temptation: Jesús, now fully transformed, is confronted with Aurora's blood and refuses it, destroying the device and choosing death. The film's Christology is exact. Its Jesus is the one who will not drink, and his resurrection is real but unwanted, a condition he renounces rather than a triumph he enjoys.

Blade II extends the analysis to the system. The Reapers are vampires that feed on vampires, an image of chronophagy turned recursive, the devourers devoured by the logic of their own appetite. Their origin is the eugenic project of the vampire lord Damaskinos, and their patient zero is his son Nomak, whose rebellion is patricidal. The film's most quietly radical moment belongs to Damaskinos's daughter Nyssa, who, infected and dying, asks Blade to carry her into the sunrise and dissolves in his arms: a vampire who chooses mortal dawn over the counterfeit eternity of her father's house. The image returns, transfigured, at the close of *Frankenstein* (2025).

The Strain makes explicit what the earlier films implied. Its vampirism is a parasitic infection; its human collaborator is the dying billionaire Eldritch Palmer; its most vicious vampire, Thomas Eichhorst, was a commandant at Treblinka, the extermination camp in occupied Poland where the SS and its auxiliaries murdered hundreds of thousands of Jews in 1942 and 1943; and its hero, Abraham Setrakian, is a survivor of that camp who keeps his dead wife's heart alive in a jar, feeding it with his own blood. The series fuses the three historical chronophagies of the twentieth century, fascism, finance capital, and the

biopolitical management of life, under the sign of the vampire, while Setrakian's terrible devotion figures the inverse economy: blood given, not taken, even to the dead.

2.3 *Kenosis: The Self-Emptying God*

Paul's hymn in Philippians 2:6–8 describes Christ, who "made himself of no reputation" (*heauton ekenōsen*, "emptied himself"), taking the form of a servant and becoming obedient unto death. Kenosis is the theological antonym of chronophagy. Where Saturn preserves himself by consuming his children, the kenotic god expends himself so that others may live. Del Toro's heroes are kenotic figures, though his films detach kenosis from the obedience Paul praised and reattach it to disobedience.

The pattern is consistent. Jesús Gris renounces immortality to spare his granddaughter. Ofelia sheds her own blood rather than her brother's. Pinocchio breaks Death's hourglass to return early and save Geppetto, surrendering the deathlessness that the Podestà coveted. Sebastian J. Cricket spends the wish he has been promised on Pinocchio's revival rather than on himself. The Amphibian Man, worshipped as a god in the Amazon and chained in a Baltimore laboratory, is a suffering servant in the idiom of Isaiah 53, "despised and rejected of men", who heals wounds and restores Elisa to life; yet del Toro guards against sentimental divinity by having him devour Giles's cat. The Creature of *Frankenstein* (2025), immortal and abused, forgives the father who made and tormented him.

Simone Weil is the indispensable interlocutor here, and not only because she is the twentieth century's most rigorous philosopher of kenosis. Her concept of *décréation* names the undoing of the self's claim to centrality; her account of *malheur*, affliction, describes suffering that reduces a person to a thing; and her essay "The Iliad, or the Poem of Force" (1940–41) defines force as that which turns anybody subjected to it into a thing. Weil joined the anarchist militias in Spain in 1936, and her 1938 letter to Georges Bernanos recounted with unsparing honesty the killings carried out on her own side, as she saw them or heard them told by comrades, among them the shooting of a captured adolescent found with a Falangist card after, by her account, Durruti had given him a day to recant; later research suggests she recomposed the episode and may have misassigned Durruti's part in it. Her refusal to grant any faction innocence

anticipates del Toro's refusal to sentimentalise the Republican camp: Jacinto in *The Devil's Backbone* is a product of the Republic's own orphanage, and the boys who kill him do so with sharpened sticks. Bernanos himself, in *Les Grands Cimetières sous la lune* (1938), denounced the summary executions of suspected Republicans carried out on Mallorca from 1936 by Nationalist soldiers and Falangist squads, later with the help of the Italian fascist Arconovaldo Bonaccorsi, which he put at some three thousand dead, and the island's bishop and clergy who supported them, establishing the lineage of Catholic anti-fascism to which del Toro belongs. That lineage appears in *Pan's Labyrinth* in a single exchange at Vidal's table, where a priest remarks that God has already saved the rebels' souls and that what happens to their bodies hardly concerns Him. Spiritualisation becomes the alibi for violence against the body, and the film's entire theology is a rebuttal of that sentence.

2.4 *The Gospel of the Monster*

René Girard's *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) and *Le Bouc émissaire* (1982) argued that archaic societies resolve mimetic crises by collectively murdering a victim, whom myth then represents as guilty: Oedipus really did kill his father and pollute Thebes. The Gospels, for Girard, are unique in narrating the same mechanism from the side of the victim and thereby revealing the victim's innocence. Del Toro's monster films are gospels in Girard's precise sense. They take the classic monster narrative, in which the community's violence against the anomalous creature is justified by the creature's menace, and retell it from the creature's side. *Frankenstein* (2025) makes this structural, dividing itself into Victor's tale and the Creature's tale, so that the persecutor's account is followed and corrected by the victim's.

Pinocchio contains the corpus's most concentrated Girardian scene. Entering a church, the newly animated puppet is met with terror by the congregation, and he asks why they love the wooden figure on the crucifix and fear him, since both are made of wood. The question exposes the structure Girard described: a community that worships a victim once he is dead and safely sacralised, and persecutes the living anomaly who resembles him.

2.5 *Sacrifice and Its Feminist Critique*

Feminist theology has long identified sacrificial atonement as a site of patriarchal violence. Mary Daly's *Beyond God the Father* (1973) argued that a male God legitimates male dominance. Joanne Carlson Brown and Rebecca Parker's "For God So Loved the World?" (1989) characterised substitutionary atonement, in which a father requires the death of his son, as a theology that sanctifies abuse, and the phrase "divine child abuse" became a touchstone of the debate. The structure they indict is Saturn's: a father who secures order through the death of his child.

Del Toro's theology aligns with this critique while preserving what feminist theologians often discarded. He rejects sacrifice demanded by a father, a state, or a god, and retains kenosis offered by the vulnerable on behalf of the more vulnerable. The distinction is between a death required and a life given. Chapter Four will test whether the distinction holds under the pressure of Ofelia's death, and will argue that it holds only partially, which is itself instructive.

2.6 *Sister Bodily Death: Creaturely Catholicism*

Francis of Assisi's *Canticle of the Creatures* praises God for Brother Sun and Sister Moon and, in its final strophes, for "sora nostra Morte corporale", our Sister Bodily Death, from whom no living person can escape. Francis converts death from an enemy to be conquered into a sibling to be welcomed. *Pinocchio* stages this conversion literally: Death and the Wood Sprite are sisters, both played by Tilda Swinton, and the being who animates the puppet is kin to the being who receives him. The cosmology is Franciscan. Mortality is not the defeat of life but a member of its family.

Eric Santner's *On Creaturely Life* (2006) defines the creaturely as the exposure of human life to the excesses of sovereign power, the point at which the human comes closest to the animal at the very moment of their difference. Del Toro's monsters are creatures in both the Franciscan and the Santnerian sense: made things, exposed things, things that power wounds. At the 2018 Golden Globes del Toro called monsters the "patron saints of our blissful imperfection", a phrase that compresses his theology into seven words. His collection at Bleak House functions as a secular reliquary, and his films as hagiographies in

which the saint is the creature that the world found unbearable. This is the content of what I call creaturely Catholicism: a faith whose sacred is located not in transcendence but in the wounded, the anomalous, and the mortal, and whose central sacrament is the gift of one's own life rather than the consumption of another's.



Chapter Three

The Great Amphibium

Humanist Teratology, Mimicry, and the Ontology of the Hybrid

There are no Grotesques in Nature.

Sir Thomas Browne, *Religio Medici*, 1643, Part I

3.1 *Monstrum: The Sign That Shows and Warns*

The Latin *monstrum* bears a double etymology that antiquity never resolved. Cicero, in *De divinatione* (1.93), aligned *monstra* with *monstrare*, to show; the grammarians derived the word from *monere*, to warn; and Isidore of Seville's *Etymologiae* (11.3) fused the two, holding that monsters are named from admonition because they demonstrate something by signifying it. The monster is a sign before it is a body. What the tradition contested was the referent of the sign. For the Etruscan haruspices consulted by Rome, the anomalous birth announced divine anger and required elimination: Livy (27.37) records that in 207 BCE an infant of indeterminate sex born at Frusino was sealed alive in a chest and drowned at sea. The originary scene of Western teratology is sacrificial, and its victim is a child consigned to the water. Del Toro returns to that scene and reverses its outcome. Elisa Esposito, the foundling discovered as an infant in a river with wounds on her neck, is the drowned prodigy who survives.

Augustine relocated the referent from divine wrath to human ignorance. In *The City of God* (21.8), adapting Varro, he held that a portent occurs not contrary to nature but contrary to nature as it is known; in 16.8 he extended descent from Adam to the monstrous races reported by travellers, on the sole condition that they be rational and mortal, since the Creator knows how to weave the beauty of the whole from the likeness and unlikeness of its parts. This is the theological charter of teratological humanism: the monster is not an exception to creation but a part whose place in the whole exceeds the observer's knowledge. Ambroise Paré's *Des monstres et prodiges* (1573) inherited both registers, cataloguing causes that run from the glory and wrath of God through the imagination of the mother and the narrowness of the womb to the artifice of wicked beggars. Lorraine Daston and Katharine Park (1998) traced the monster's migration between 1150 and 1750 from prodigy to wonder to natural anomaly, a migration the cabinet of curiosities mediated and the Geoffroy Saint-Hilaires completed in the 1830s by founding a science of teratology. Georges Canguilhem (1962) drew the philosophical consequence: the monster is the living being of negative value, and the monstrous discloses that the stability of living form is an achievement rather than a given. Foucault's lectures on *Abnormal* (1974–75) added the juridical dimension, defining the

human monster as the figure in which the impossible and the forbidden coincide.

Del Toro's monsters retain all four registers, prodigy, wonder, anomaly, and juridical scandal, but invert the direction of the sign. They show and they warn, yet what they warn against is the community that persecutes them. The Amphibian Man is designated "the Asset", a category that converts a worshipped being into government property; the Creature of *Frankenstein* has no name and no standing; the Judas Breed of *Mimic* is engineered biology. The juridical scandal of del Toro's monster is not that it violates the law but that the law has no place for it except as resource. The *monstrum* admonishes the chronophage.

3.2 *The Chameleon, the Custom, and the Amphibium*

Renaissance humanism produced three accounts of the indeterminate human, and del Toro's position can be fixed by its relation to each. Pico della Mirandola's *Oratio* (1486) has God tell Adam that he has been given no fixed seat, no proper face, and no peculiar function, so that he may be the free shaper (*plastes et fictor*) of himself, sinking to the brutes or rising to the divine; Pico asks who would not admire this chameleon of ours. Pico's indeterminacy is vertical and ascensional. Montaigne's "Of a Monstrous Child" (*Essais* 2.30) offers a horizontal alternative: describing a child joined at the chest to a headless twin, he concludes that what we call monsters are not so to God, who sees in the immensity of his work the infinity of forms it contains, and that we call contrary to nature what occurs contrary to custom. Browne's *Religio Medici* supplies the third account. Man is "that great and true Amphibium", disposed to live in divided and distinguished worlds, and because there is a general beauty in the works of God, Browne cannot tell by what logic we call a toad, a bear, or an elephant ugly.

Del Toro refuses Pico, radicalises Montaigne, and literalises Browne. He refuses Pico because his monsters decline the ascent: Pinocchio does not become a real boy, the Amphibian Man does not become a prince, the Creature of 2025 never becomes the triumph over death that Victor intended. He radicalises Montaigne because his chronophages are custom personified: Strickland's suburban normality, Vidal's protocol, the Podestà's catechism. He

literalises Browne because his heroes inhabit divided worlds concretely, living and dead, aquatic and terrestrial, wooden and fleshly, demonic and human.

A feminist qualification is necessary. Pico addresses Adam, and the Renaissance ideal of self-fashioning, as Stephen Greenblatt (1980) reconstructed it, was a privilege of literate men; Joan Kelly's "Did Women Have a Renaissance?" (1977) answered its own question in the negative because the expansion of male self-determination coincided with the contraction of female autonomy. Del Toro answers the exclusion by changing the structure of dignity. His creatures are not *plastes et fictor* of themselves; they are carved (Pinocchio), assembled (the Creature), engineered (the Judas Breed), summoned (Hellboy), or found (Elisa). Their dignity is heteroplastic rather than autoplastic: it belongs to the made thing that, having been made by another, chooses what to make of its having been made. Professor Broom states the principle in *Hellboy* when he tells Agent Myers that a man is defined not by his origins but by his choices, not by how he begins but by how he decides to end. Pico's freedom migrates from the moment of self-creation to the moment of ending, from sovereignty to mortality.

3.3 *Innsmouth: The Horror of Mixture and Its Reversal*

No author mattered more to del Toro's imagination than H. P. Lovecraft, and none held a more opposite view of the hybrid. Lovecraft's cosmic horror rests on two convictions: that the universe is vast, ancient, and indifferent, a conviction announced in the opening of "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928), which calls the mind's inability to correlate its contents merciful; and that the mixture of kinds is the supreme abomination. *The Shadow over Innsmouth* (1936) expresses the second conviction most purely. Its narrator discovers that a decayed Massachusetts port has interbred with the Deep Ones, amphibious beings of the sea, and that he himself, bearing the incipient "Innsmouth look", descends from that union. The story's horror is a horror of miscegenation, the term American racial law used for marriage and reproduction across the colour line, which Maryland, where del Toro would set his amphibious romance, criminalised until 1967: the narrator's descent from a union with the Deep Ones is staged as the discovery of tainted blood. Lovecraft's letters and "The Horror at Red Hook" (1927) describe New York's Jewish and immigrant residents in openly dehumanising terms (Joshi 2010), the story turning an immigrant quar-

ter of Brooklyn into a breeding ground of demonic contagion; a poem he wrote in 1912 presents Black people as a beast made in half-human form, and Michel Houellebecq (1991) argued that racial hatred supplied the trance-like intensity of his mature fiction. Yet the tale ends ambivalently, with the narrator resolving to join his kin beneath the sea.

Del Toro's career is a sustained engagement with Lovecraft's cosmology and a sustained repudiation of his affect. Universal declined to finance his adaptation of *At the Mountains of Madness* in 2011, but its imagery saturates the corpus: the tentacled Ogdru Jahad of *Hellboy*, the Behemoth that Hellboy destroys from inside, the interdimensional Breach and colonising Precursors of *Pacific Rim*. Del Toro preserves the cosmos's indifferent immensity while reversing the moral valence of mixture: xenophobia becomes xenophilia, and the amphibious descendant becomes the beloved. Donna Haraway performs the same operation in theory. The "Chthulucene" of *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) borrows the tentacular and the chthonic while explicitly repudiating Lovecraft's misogynist and racial nightmare, altering the spelling to mark the difference. What Innsmouth discovers as damnation, *The Shape of Water* stages as grace (Chapter Six).

3.4 *Mimicry: The Judas Breed and the Ambivalence of Resemblance*

Mimic is the corpus's meditation on resemblance. To halt an epidemic of Strickler's disease, carried by cockroaches and killing the children of Manhattan, the entomologist Susan Tyler engineers the Judas Breed, a termite-mantis hybrid designed to exterminate the vector and then die out. Three years later the species has survived, bred, and evolved to imitate its only predator, folding its wings into the silhouette of a man in a dark overcoat. Roger Caillois's "Mimétisme et psychasthénie légendaire" (1935) argued that mimicry is less an adaptive defence than a temptation by space, a disturbance in which the organism loses its distinction from its surroundings and becomes not similar to something but simply similar. Homi Bhabha's "Of Mimicry and Man" (1984) transposed the problem into colonial discourse: the colonised subject trained to imitate the coloniser becomes "almost the same, but not quite", and the slippage menaces the authority it was meant to confirm.

The Judas Breed stages Bhabha's ambivalence as horror. A creature engineered as an instrument returns as a subject that imitates its master, and the

imitation terrifies because it reveals the human form as imitable: a silhouette, a coat, a posture in the dark. The name completes the Christological irony: the engineered disciple betrays its maker. The only character who reads the mimic correctly is Chuy, a neurodivergent boy who knows people by the sound of their shoes and names the creature "Mr. Funny Shoes". The shoe, which recurs from the heap beneath the Pale Man's table to the single red shoe clutched by the child Mako Mori in *Pacific Rim*, marks in del Toro the trace of the devoured or endangered child, and it is fitting that the first being to perceive the hybrid accurately is a child whom normative adulthood regards as deficient.

3.5 *Mestizo Monstrosity: Coatlicue, Nepantla, and the Refusal of the Cosmic Race*

The Mexican genealogy of del Toro's monsters begins in stone. The colossal statue of Coatlicue, the serpent-skirted earth mother wearing a necklace of hands and hearts, was excavated in Mexico City's main square in 1790 and reburied soon afterward, lest it revive indigenous devotion; it was not definitively exhumed until after Independence. The colonial order could neither destroy nor display the monstrous sacred, so it buried it, and the gesture prefigures every cellar, cistern, and tank in which del Toro's institutions conceal what they cannot assimilate. Gloria Anzaldúa's *Borderlands/La Frontera* (1987) made Coatlicue the emblem of a psychic descent that precedes transformation and derived from it a mestiza consciousness defined by "a tolerance for ambiguity"; her later concept of *nepantla*, the Nahuatl word for the space in-between, names those who live across worlds and mediate between them.

Anzaldúa's mestiza consciousness must be distinguished from the official mestizaje of José Vasconcelos's *La raza cósmica* (1925), which prophesied a fifth, universal race synthesised in Latin America and rested the prophecy on what Vasconcelos himself called aesthetic eugenics: he wrote that the ugliest stocks would gradually give way to the most beautiful, and that a few decades of such eugenics could make Black people disappear. Vasconcelos's hybridity is teleological and finally purifying: mixture is a stage toward a superior unity that consumes its components. It is, in this dissertation's terms, a chronophagic mestizaje, in which the future race devours the peoples it claims to fulfil. Del Toro's hybridity is non-teleological. His amphibia do not resolve into a higher synthesis; they persist in doubleness. Hellboy remains demon and son,

Pinocchio wood and child, the Amphibian Man god and animal. They are *nepantleras* who hold the in-between open, and del Toro's own career across Guadalajara, Madrid, Hollywood, and Toronto is the professional analogue of their condition.

3.6 *The Axolotl Principle: Neoteny as Dignity*

The axolotl of the Introduction can now be given its conceptual weight. The animal is neotenic: it keeps its larval gills throughout life, reproduces without completing metamorphosis, and regenerates limbs, organs, and portions of its nervous system. Louis Bolk's *Das Problem der Menschwerdung* (1926) proposed that the human being is a fetalised primate that retains into adulthood features its ancestors displayed only as juveniles, and Stephen Jay Gould's *Ontogeny and Phylogeny* (1977) returned neoteny to the centre of evolutionary debate, linking human capacities to the prolonged dependency and plasticity of childhood. Giorgio Agamben's "Idea of Infancy" (1985) drew the philosophical consequence through the image of the axolotl itself: the human is the animal that remains in infancy, unspecialised, without a prescribed environment, and therefore open to possibility.

Two Latin American texts complete the figure. Julio Cortázar's "Axolotl", collected in *Final del juego* (1956), narrates a man who watches the axolotls in the aquarium of the Jardin des Plantes until his consciousness passes into one of them and he looks out through the glass at the man he was. Roger Bartra's *La jaula de la melancolía* (1987) showed how twentieth-century Mexican intellectuals used the axolotl as the emblem of a supposedly arrested national character, larval and melancholy, unable to complete its metamorphosis into modernity, and dismantled that myth as an instrument of state nationalism. Del Toro transvalues the emblem Bartra deconstructed. Neoteny in his films is not arrested development but the form of dignity: the refusal to complete the metamorphosis demanded by the adult world, whether that demand comes as Vidal's soldiering, the Podestà's war, Disney's "real boy", or Beaumont's prince. I call this the *axolotl principle*: dignity resides in what remains open, unfinished, regenerative, and capable of living in two elements. Joined to the myth of Xolotl, who refused sacrifice and fled into the water, the principle acquires its ethical edge. The neotenic being declines both the metamorphosis that would normalise it and the death that would consecrate it.

3.7 *The Cat Problem: Between Humanist Purity and Posthumanist Dissolution*

Teratological humanism must be defended on two fronts. Against classical humanism, it denies that dignity is a species property grounded in rational nature. Against contemporary posthumanism, it refuses to dissolve the human into a flat ontology of life. Rosi Braidotti's *The Posthuman* (2013) proposes an egalitarianism of *zoe* that dethrones the human altogether, and Cary Wolfe (2010) has exposed the speciesism embedded in humanist ethics. Del Toro shares the critique but not the conclusion. He retains "human" as a normative honorific, a name for a capacity rather than a kind, which a demon, an amphibian, a puppet, or a reanimated corpse may earn and a captain, colonel, or baronet may forfeit. Agamben's *The Open* (2002) describes the "anthropological machine" by which modernity produces the human by excluding the animal within it, generating zones of indistinction in which some humans are reduced to bare life. *Nightmare Alley*'s geek, a destitute alcoholic exhibited as a beast to paying crowds, is that machine's product, and the barker's question whether he is man or beast is the machine's own question, posed for profit. Del Toro jams the machine not by excluding the animal from the human but by locating the human in the monster.

The decisive test is what I call the cat problem. Montaigne, in the "Apology for Raymond Sebond" (*Essais* 2.12), wondered whether, when he played with his cat, she was not amusing herself with him more than he with her. Derrida's *The Animal That Therefore I Am* (2006) began from his own cat looking at him naked and insisted, citing Montaigne, that this was a real cat and not an allegory. *The Shape of Water* gives the corpus's answer. The Amphibian Man, sheltered in Giles's apartment, decapitates and eats one of Giles's cats. The scene is not a lapse in the film's sympathy but a guarantee against sentimental appropriation. The monster is not an allegory of innocence but an animal with appetites, and the film stays with the trouble, in Haraway's phrase, rather than purifying its beloved into a symbol. Teratological humanism is thus neither the humanism of purity nor the posthumanism of dissolution. It is a humanism of the amphibium, locating the human in the capacity to dwell in divided worlds, to remain unfinished, and to refuse both the metamorphosis that normalises and the sacrifice that consecrates.



Chapter Four

Against Abraham

Disobedience, Childhood, and the Anti-Fascist Triptych

But the old man would not so, but slew his son,
And half the seed of Europe, one by one.

Wilfred Owen, "The Parable of the Old Man and the Young", 1918

4.1 *The Akedah and Its Discontents*

Genesis 22 narrates the founding scene of Western obedience. God commands Abraham to take his son, his only son, whom he loves, and offer him as a burnt offering on Moriah; Abraham rises early, cleaves the wood, binds Isaac on the altar, and stretches out his hand before an angel stays it. Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) made the episode the paradigm of faith: Abraham's readiness to kill Isaac constitutes a "teleological suspension of the ethical", in which the individual stands in absolute relation to the absolute above the universal law and cannot justify himself in ethical terms. Kant had answered in advance. In *The Conflict of the Faculties* (1798) he wrote that Abraham should have replied to the supposedly divine voice that it is certain he ought not to kill his good son, but not certain that the voice is God's. Levinas, in a commentary of 1966, located the summit of the drama not in Abraham's obedience to the first voice but in his attentiveness to the second, which recalled him to the ethical order. Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (1992) generalised the scene: every responsibility to one other sacrifices all the others, so that the Akedah is enacted daily.

Owen's parable supplies the political translation that del Toro presupposes. In the poem the angel offers the Ram of Pride in Isaac's place, but the old man refuses and slays his son, and with him half the seed of Europe. The Akedah becomes the type of the First World War: the old sacrifice the young to an abstraction they call God, country, or honour. In Owen, Abraham and Saturn converge. The father who sacrifices the son at a sovereign's command and the father who devours the son to preserve his sovereignty are one figure seen from two sides, and del Toro's anti-fascist films are organised around the refusal of both.

4.2 *Poisonous Pedagogy and the Ethics of Disobedience*

The fascist father is first an educator. Katharina Rutschky's anthology *Schwarze Pädagogik* (1977) assembled two centuries of German manuals devoted to breaking the child's will, and Alice Miller's *Am Anfang war Erziehung* (1980), translated as *For Your Own Good*, argued that this "poisonous pedagogy" produced adults ready to obey without conscience and to visit on others the cru-

elty once visited on them. Vidal, who repeats to himself the legend of his father's watch; the Podestà of *Pinocchio*, who drills his son Candlewick for war and shames his weakness; and, as Chapter Seven will show, Leopold Frankenstein, who beats his son for errors in anatomy, are figures of poisonous pedagogy. Each transmits obedience as patrimony.

Twentieth-century moral philosophy developed a corresponding ethics of disobedience. Erich Fromm's essay "Disobedience as a Psychological and Moral Problem" (1963) argued that human history began with an act of disobedience and may well end with one of obedience, the obedience of officials who launch nuclear weapons on command. Hannah Arendt's *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963) reported the claim of Adolf Eichmann, the SS officer who organised the deportation of Europe's Jews to the ghettos and killing centres, to have lived by Kant's precepts, which he had reduced to acting as the Führer would approve, and her lecture "Personal Responsibility Under Dictatorship" (1964) concluded that in moral matters no one has the right to obey. Foucault's "What Is Critique?" (1978) defined critique as the art of not being governed quite so much. Stanley Milgram (1963) had meanwhile shown that ordinary subjects would administer what they believed were dangerous shocks when instructed by an authority in a laboratory coat. Against this background Dr. Ferreiro's reply to Vidal in *Pan's Labyrinth* acquires its full weight. Vidal has tortured a captured guerrilla, a young man with a stammer; left alone with the doctor, the prisoner begs to be killed, and Ferreiro gives him a lethal injection. Asked why he disobeyed, Ferreiro answers that to obey for obedience's sake (*obedecer por obedecer*), without thinking, is something only men like the captain do, and Vidal shoots him in the back as he walks away. Ferreiro's is the corpus's hardest case of disobedience: it ends a life, at the victim's own plea, so that the torturer can no longer use it.

Sara Ahmed's *Willful Subjects* (2014) supplies the feminist frame. Ahmed begins from the Grimms' "The Willful Child", in which a child who will not do as her mother wishes is allowed by God to sicken and die, and whose arm keeps rising out of the grave until the mother strikes it with a rod, after which the child at last has rest. Willfulness, for Ahmed, is the charge levelled at those whose wills do not coincide with the general will of family, nation, or institution, and feminist politics consists partly in claiming that charge. Del Toro's children are willful in Ahmed's sense, and his films are the arm that keeps rising from the grave.

4.3 The Devil's Backbone*: The Bomb, the Cistern, and the Republic's Orphans*

The Devil's Backbone (2001) is set in 1939, in the war's last months, at a remote orphanage for the children of Republican militants. An unexploded bomb stands in its courtyard, defused but never removed, and the children believe it is still alive: the fascist future suspended over the Republic's children, an instrument of death delivered from the sky that has not yet gone off. Beneath the house, in a cistern, lies the body of Santi, a boy murdered by Jacinto, the former orphan turned caretaker who covets the Republican gold hidden in the institution's safe. Dr. Casares, the elderly, impotent humanist played by Federico Luppi, keeps in jars of rum the fetuses of children born with spina bifida, the "devil's backbone" of the title, whose liquor the villagers prize as a remedy. The detail binds the film's two concerns: children whom a eugenic imagination would never have allowed to be born, and a liberal humanism that can preserve what it cannot save.

Jacinto is the film's most disturbing figure because he is the Republic's own product. Raised in the orphanage, he converts the foundling's humiliation into greed, so that the chronophage is not an external fascist but the institution's failed son. After he sets the fire that kills Carmen and several children and leaves Casares mortally wounded, the surviving boys arm themselves with sharpened sticks, wound him, and drive him into the cistern, where, his pockets weighted with the gold he coveted, he is drawn under by Santi's ghost. The film does not sentimentalise this justice. Albert Camus's *L'Homme révolté* (1951) is apposite: revolt founds solidarity ("I rebel, therefore we exist") but remains bound by a limit, and Camus's "fastidious assassins" of 1905 held that whoever kills must accept his own death. The boys do not die, but the final image places them, wounded and orphaned, walking into the desert under the gaze of Casares's ghost, who guards a house no one will return to. The Republic survives as a ghost watching its children walk away.

The film descends from Víctor Erice's *El espíritu de la colmena* (1973). There, in a Castilian village in 1940, the child Ana sees James Whale's *Frankenstein* at a travelling screening and asks why the monster killed the girl and why the villagers killed him; she then finds and feeds a wounded Republican fugitive hiding in a sheepfold, who is shot by the Guardia Civil, and her father's musical pocket watch, recovered from the dead man, exposes her secret when it chimes

at the family table. Erice made the post-war child's encounter with the Frankenstein myth the privileged form in which Spanish cinema could address the repressed Republic under censorship, and he made the paternal timepiece its instrument of discipline. Del Toro inherits both; *Frankenstein* (2025) returns to their source. His Spanish films were also made at a precise moment. The *pacto del olvido* of the Transition, codified in the Amnesty Law of 1977, a law that also shielded the dictatorship's officials from prosecution, had left in roadside ditches and mass graves the people shot by Nationalist troops and Falangist squads during the war and by the regime in the repression that followed, while the regime had long since recovered and honoured the dead of killings in the Republican zone. In October 2000 Emilio Silva arranged the exhumation of the ditch at Priaranza del Bierzo, in León, where a Falangist squad had buried his grandfather, Emilio Silva Faba, with twelve other men it shot in October 1936, and with Santiago Macías he founded the Asociación para la Recuperación de la Memoria Histórica; in 2007 parliament passed the Law of Historical Memory; and in 2008 the judge Baltasar Garzón opened an investigation into the crimes of the Franco regime whose lists counted more than 114,000 people disappeared. Released at the start of the exhumation movement, *The Devil's Backbone* is a film about a body in the water beneath a house, waiting to be found.

4.4 Pan's Labyrinth*: Antigone Doubled*

Pan's Labyrinth (2006) is set in 1944, when the guerrilla resistance of the *maquis* continued in the mountains after the war's end. Its structure rests on a doubling criticism has not sufficiently remarked: two sisters each protect a brother against a sovereign command. Mercedes, the housekeeper, secretly supplies her brother Pedro and his comrades against Vidal's orders; Ofelia refuses to surrender her infant half-brother to the Faun. The archetype is Sophocles' *Antigone*, which Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) read as a collision between the divine law of the family and the human law of the state. Irigaray's *Speculum of the Other Woman* (1974) and Judith Butler's *Antigone's Claim* (2000) contested that reading: for Irigaray, Antigone embodies the relation to blood and burial the Hegelian state must repress; for Butler, she exposes the contingency of the kinship norms on which the state depends. Del Toro distributes

Antigone's defiance between a woman and a girl, one in the realist plot and one in the fantastic, so that the film's two worlds share a single ethical form.

Mercedes's defiance is armed. Having captured her, Vidal dismisses his subordinate on the assumption that a woman needs no guarding, and the assumption is fatal: she cuts her bonds with the knife hidden in her apron, stabs him, and slits his mouth open before fleeing. When the guerrillas finally confront Vidal at the labyrinth, he surrenders his infant son to Mercedes and begins to instruct her to tell the boy the hour of his father's death, repeating the ritual of the watch. Mercedes interrupts: the son will not even know his name. Pedro shoots him. Patrilineal transmission, the passage of name and watch from father to son, is severed by a woman's refusal, and the child will grow up outside the father's time.

Ofelia's trials turn on a distinction between two disobediences. At the Pale Man's table she is forbidden to eat, but she takes two grapes, the monster wakes, and two of her fairy guides are devoured. This is the disobedience of appetite, an Edenic transgression that briefly aligns her with Saturn's feast, and it has victims. Her final disobedience is of another order. The Faun commands her to let a few drops of her brother's blood be shed, since the portal opens only with the blood of an innocent; she refuses, and Vidal, following her, takes the child and shoots her. Her blood falls into the labyrinth, and in the underground kingdom her father, the King, reveals that her refusal to shed innocent blood was the final test. The disobedience of conscience redeems the disobedience of appetite. Fromm's thesis is thereby refined: there are two disobediences, one that consumes and one that refuses to consume, and only the second is the ethical act.

4.5 *Ofelia's Death and the Limits of Kenosis*

Chapter Two promised to test whether del Toro's distinction between sacrifice demanded and life given survives Ofelia's death. It survives only partially. The surface opposes the Faun's demand for the child's blood to Ofelia's gift of her own, yet the King's revelation retroactively places that demand inside a test the King himself designed, a test whose passing coincides with the death of the one who passes it. The kingdom's father is also an Abraham, authorising a trial of his daughter's fidelity whose structure requires her blood and rewarding her with a throne at his side. Elisabeth Bronfen's *Over Her Dead Body* (1992) ana-

lysed the aesthetic economy in which the beautiful dead woman secures a culture's meanings; Ofelia, whose name recalls the drowned Ophelia, is exposed to that economy, and the film's luminous final images risk making a girl's death the proof of her goodness.

There is a further irony. A film honouring the Republican resistance ends with its heroine's apotheosis into a monarchy. Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* (1954–59) defended the fairy tale as an anticipatory illumination (*Vor-Schein*) of a just world, while Jack Zipes (1979, 1983) emphasised the genre's double nature, utopian in longing and conservative in form. *Pan's Labyrinth* exemplifies that doubleness: utopian content, the triumph of the child who will not shed innocent blood, in the obsolete iconography of royalty. The film half-concedes the problem in its epilogue, which says the princess left small traces of her time on earth, visible only to those who know where to look, and shows a white flower opening on the dead fig tree. Utopia withdraws into the trace. The feminist critique of sacrificial atonement (Brown and Parker) holds against the film's narrative structure even as its ethical content anticipates their conclusion.

4.6 Pinocchio*: The Disobedient Wood*

Guillermo del Toro's Pinocchio (2022), co-directed with Mark Gustafson, is the third panel of what del Toro has called a loose trilogy with the two Spanish films, and it is the panel in which the triptych corrects itself. Collodi's *Le avventure di Pinocchio* (1883) punishes disobedience, often grotesquely, and rewards eventual docility with transformation into a real boy; Disney's version (1940) softened the punishments but kept the structure, making real boyhood the prize for proving oneself brave, truthful, and unselfish under an appointed conscience. Del Toro inverts both. His Pinocchio is born of grief: Geppetto's son Carlo is killed in the First World War by a bomb jettisoned from an aircraft over the village church, and the puppet is carved in drunken despair from the pine that grew from a cone planted by the boy's grave. The cricket, Sebastian J., lives inside the wood. Del Toro has stated in interviews that he conceived the film as an argument for disobedience as a virtue.

The setting is Mussolini's Italy, and the Podestà covets Pinocchio because a boy who cannot die would make the perfect soldier. Pinocchio's immortality is governed by Death, a sister of the Wood Sprite who animated him, whose

hourglasses require him to wait longer in the afterlife each time he returns. The fascist reads this condition as an asset; the film reads it as a burden that love will surrender. In the decisive episode Pinocchio returns early from the afterlife to save Geppetto, breaking Death's rule and forfeiting his immortality, and Sebastian spends the wish promised to him to revive the boy. The kenotic chain runs through puppet, cricket, and father, and its result is not transfiguration but mortality accepted. Pinocchio does not become a real boy. He remains wood, loved as he is: the axolotl principle (Chapter Three) as fairy tale. Two further liberations complete the pattern. Candlewick, the Podestà's son, learns from Pinocchio to defy his father, and Spazzatura, the abused monkey of the showman Count Volpe, whose name means rubbish, finally turns against his master. The child and the animal are freed together from the same pedagogy of domination.

The ending answers Herodotus. Croesus, brought before Cyrus, observes that in peace sons bury their fathers, while in war fathers bury their sons (*Histories* 1.87). *Pinocchio* begins in the order of war, with Geppetto weeping at Carlo's grave, and ends in the order of peace: years pass, and the wooden boy buries in turn Geppetto, Sebastian, and Spazzatura before walking out into the world, as the narration accepts that what happens happens and then we are gone. Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) illuminates the passage. Geppetto first relates to Pinocchio melancholically, measuring the living boy against the lost one; he completes the work of mourning only when he loves Pinocchio as himself rather than as Carlo's substitute. Saturn's inversion of succession is undone by the most ordinary outcome: the child outlives the parent.

4.7 *The Arc of the Triptych*

Read together, the three films trace a development. *The Devil's Backbone* centres on a murdered child who becomes a ghost; *Pan's Labyrinth* on a child who dies and is exalted; *Pinocchio* on a child who survives, grieves, and lives on. The triptych moves from ghost to martyr to survivor, and in that movement the corpus corrects its own sacrificial structure: the child is no longer required to die to prove the goodness of disobedience. The arc also clarifies the relation between violence and refusal. The orphans kill; Mercedes wounds and Pedro kills; Pinocchio kills no one. The triptych does not condemn the earlier vio-

lence, which is defensive and aimed at chronophages, but it culminates in a disobedience that requires no blood at all.



Chapter Five

Houses That Breathe, Ghosts That Testify

The Female Gothic and the Spectral Archive

Even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins.

Walter Benjamin, "Theses on the Philosophy of History", 1940, trans. Harry Zohn

5.1 *The Female Gothic and the Woman Who Writes*

Ellen Moers coined the term "female Gothic" in *Literary Women* (1976) for the work women had done in the Gothic mode since Ann Radcliffe, a mode in which the heroine is at once persecuted victim and courageous explorer of forbidden interiors, and through which anxieties about confinement, sexuality, and childbirth could be encoded. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) read the Gothic house as the architecture of patriarchal enclosure and its imprisoned madwoman as the woman writer's double. The template is Perrault's "La Barbe bleue" (1697): a husband's forbidden chamber, the corpses of earlier wives, a key that will not stop bleeding. Angela Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" (1979) rewrote the tale so that the heroine is saved not by her brothers but by her mother, who rides to the castle and shoots the Marquis. Cinema developed its own branch in Hitchcock's *Rebecca* (1940), George Cukor's *Gaslight* (1944), and the cycle Mary Ann Doane (1987) termed the "paranoid woman's film", in which a wife comes to suspect that her husband means to kill her and the house becomes the instrument of her surveillance.

Crimson Peak (2015) recapitulates this genealogy with programmatic self-awareness and names its matriarch in its first act. Edith Cushing, an aspiring novelist in Buffalo at the turn of the twentieth century, is told that a woman writer should emulate Jane Austen and replies that she would rather be Mary Shelley, who died a widow. The line establishes a lineage, the Gothic rather than the marriage plot, and a programme, the heroine's survival of her husband. Edith also insists that her manuscript is not a ghost story but a story with a ghost in it, the ghost being a metaphor for the past, a formula del Toro has applied to the film itself. Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975) urged women to write themselves into the texts from which they had been driven; Edith's authorship begins with a visitation from her dead mother, who warns her against the house she will later enter, and ends with a book that bears that house's name. The female Gothic in del Toro is a genre of maternal transmission: a warning passed from a dead woman to a living one across the barrier that patriarchal domesticity erects between them.

5.2 *Allerdale Hall: Architecture as Anatomy and Extraction*

Allerdale Hall, the Sharpe estate in Cumberland, is del Toro's most complete fusion of architecture and organism. It stands on red clay that seeps through its floorboards and stains the snow, earning it the name Crimson Peak; its ruined roof admits leaves and snow into the central hall; it exhales through its chimneys when the wind moves; and it is sinking into the ground whose clay the family mines. Del Toro has described the house as a living body, and it behaves as one, breathing, bleeding, and decaying. It is also an economic machine. Thomas Sharpe's invention, a mechanical harvester for the clay, is financed by the fortunes of the wives he and Lucille have poisoned, and the murdered women were consigned to vats of liquid clay in the cellar, so that their bodies became the material of the extraction their money funded. Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) argued that primitive accumulation in early modern Europe depended on appropriating women's bodies and labour as natural resources; Allerdale Hall miniaturises that history as domestic Gothic.

Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1958) described the house as the shelter of daydreaming, organised vertically between the rational attic and the irrational cellar. Del Toro inverts Bachelard: his houses do not shelter dreams but digest their inhabitants, and their cellars, the orphanage's cistern and Allerdale's vats, are stomachs. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) located the *unheimlich* in the homely become strange, the return of the familiar and repressed, and Anthony Vidler's *The Architectural Uncanny* (1992) extended the concept to modern space. Del Toro's houses are uncanny in the strict Freudian sense, because what returns in them is the violence that made them homes.

At the centre of the house is the incestuous bond between Thomas and Lucille. Lucille killed their mother when she discovered the siblings' relationship, and she kills Thomas when he finally chooses Edith. Butler reads Antigone's devotion to her brother as exceeding the kinship norms on which the state rests; Lucille is Antigone curdled into Saturn. Where Antigone buries her brother against the sovereign, Lucille entombs hers alive in an endogamous household that refuses the stranger, the future, and the world. Read with Mercedes and Ofelia (Chapter Four) and with Nuala of *Hellboy II* (Chapter Eight), Lucille completes a typology of sisters that runs through the corpus: the sister who protects the brother against the sovereign, the sister who pos-

sesses the brother against the world, and the sister who sacrifices herself to end the brother's violence.

5.3 *The Ghost as Witness*

Jacques Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) proposed hauntology as an ethics of learning to live with ghosts, a responsibility toward those no longer or not yet present that is the condition of any justice. Avery Gordon's *Ghostly Matters* (1997) grounded the concept sociologically: haunting is how abusive systems of power make themselves known in everyday life, and the ghost is a social figure that demands a "something-to-be-done". Jo Labanyi (2000) applied the framework to post-Franco Spain, where the unburied dead returned in film and fiction as the Transition's repressed. Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok's concept of the phantom, the gap left in a subject by the unspeakable secrets of an earlier generation, adds the transgenerational dimension: a nation, like a family, can be haunted by what its ancestors could not say.

Del Toro's ghosts form a precise typology. Testifying ghosts, Santi and the murdered brides of *Crimson Peak*, seek to be known and to warn. Guardian ghosts, Casares over the orphanage and Edith's mother over her daughter, protect. Bound ghosts, of whom Lucille playing the piano in the empty house after her death is the type, remain chained to the place they refused to leave in life. The counterfeit ghost of *Nightmare Alley* is treated below. The testifying ghosts are terrifying, but the terror is a hermeneutic error. In *Crimson Peak* the brides rise from the clay, red and skeletal, and Edith flees before she understands that they have come to warn her; the horror lies in the living's misreading of testimony as threat. Santi does take vengeance on Jacinto, but his violence is targeted, the completion of an interrupted justice rather than indiscriminate terror, and it is consummated by the living boys' collective act. Del Toro's ghosts are in this sense testimonial rather than vindictive: they seek recognition, and they act only to finish what the law of the living left undone.

Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) supply the political vocabulary. Grievability is unequally distributed; some lives are framed in advance as not quite lives, and their loss does not register as loss. Del Toro's ghosts are the ungrievable who insist on being grieved: Republican children in a cistern, wives dissolved in clay, a girl who dies in a labyrinth. Benjamin's sixth thesis, from which this chapter takes its epigraph, warned that

a victorious enemy endangers even the dead, since victory includes the power to decide how the vanquished are remembered. Mercedes's last words to Vidal turn the warning against the fascist: the defeated deny the victor his afterlife in memory.

5.4 *Wax and Glass: The Counter-Archive*

Edith learns the truth of Allerdale Hall from wax-cylinder recordings in which the earlier wives speak. The detail is historically exact and theoretically charged. When Thomas Edison listed the uses of his phonograph in 1878, he included a family record preserving the voices of relatives and the last words of the dying; Friedrich Kittler's *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986) argued that technical media redraw the boundaries of the realm of the dead, which becomes coextensive with a culture's capacity to store and replay. In *Crimson Peak* the household's apparatus of storage becomes its victims' testimony; the archive turns on its keepers. *Nightmare Alley* presents the inverse in Lilith Ritter's hidden disc recordings of her patients, an archive of powerful men's secrets deployed as a weapon. The corpus thus contrasts two archival practices: one that preserves the voices of the dispossessed, and one that hoards the confessions of the powerful for leverage.

The first practice has a demanding analogue. Saidiya Hartman's "Venus in Two Acts" (2008) confronted the archive of the Atlantic slave trade, in which enslaved girls survive only as names attached to records of their rape, torture, and death at the hands of slavers, ship captains, and crews, and proposed "critical fabulation", which combines archival research with narrative to imagine what the archive forecloses without reproducing its violence. Hartman's method belongs to a specific history and cannot be detached from it, but by analogy it clarifies what del Toro's fantastic attempts for the unmarked dead of his own subjects: a fabulation that restores voice where the record holds only silence. Ann Cvetkovich's *An Archive of Feelings* (2003) likewise theorised archives of trauma that preserve affect rather than documents. Toni Morrison's *Beloved* (1987) is the supreme literary instance. Its house at 124 Bluestone Road is haunted by the daughter Sethe killed to save her from re-enslavement, and Morrison's "rememory", memory that persists in places independently of the one who remembers, describes exactly how del Toro's houses store violence in matter: in clay, water, and walls. *Beloved* also poses, with a severity del Toro

approaches only from a distance, the question whether any death can be other than sacrificial in a world organised by those who consume children.

5.5 *The Counterfeit Ghost:* Nightmare Alley

Nightmare Alley (2021) is del Toro's only feature without a supernatural element, and it is about ghosts that do not exist. Stan Carlisle learns the mentalist's verbal code from Zeena and her husband Pete, who warns him never to perform a "spook show", in which the performer lets clients believe he speaks with their dead. Stan crosses that line. With the psychiatrist Lilith Ritter, he mines her recordings to stage messages from dead sons and lovers for the rich, and for the industrialist Ezra Grindle, haunted by Dorrie, a young woman who died after he forced her to undergo an abortion, and who, he later admits, was not the only woman he harmed, he stages an apparition by costuming Molly, his partner, as the dead woman. The scheme exploits women three times over: the dead woman, whose memory is used to absolve the man responsible for her death; Molly, whose body is lent to the impersonation and whom Grindle, embracing her and discovering the deception, strikes; and grief itself, the most intimate bond with the dead, converted into revenue. The spook show is chronophagy of mourning. It feeds on the time others spend with their dead.

Lilith Ritter bears the name of the first woman of Jewish legend, who in the medieval *Alphabet of Ben Sira* refuses to lie beneath Adam and leaves Eden. She refuses subordination to Stan, outmanoeuvres him, keeps the money, and turns her recordings of his confessions against him. Doane's *Femmes Fatales* (1991) identified the femme fatale as an epistemological threat, a figure of what the male subject cannot know; del Toro's Lilith sharpens that threat into an archivist who knows more than the men who confide in her. She remains ambiguous: she preys on men who prey on women, but she also preys. The film's moral geometry closes on Stan, who beats Grindle to death when the deception fails. Having consumed the grief of others, he ends destitute and alcoholic at another carnival, is offered work as the geek, and accepts, saying he was born for it. The carnival, whose jars of malformed fetuses recall Casares's rum, is the anthropological machine of Chapter Three run as a business: a false commons that feeds on its members. The chronophage completes his cycle by becoming the devoured.

5.6 *Ghost-Mothers*

Two debut features del Toro produced extend the typology to the maternal. In J. A. Bayona's *The Orphanage* (2007), Laura returns to the orphanage of her childhood, searches for her vanished adopted son, and in death joins the ghost children as the mother they never had, a Wendy for the lost boys. In Andrés Muschietti's *Mama* (2013), the ghost of a nineteenth-century asylum inmate who leapt from a cliff with her infant adopts two abandoned girls and at the climax carries the younger over the cliff with her, both dissolving into moths. The films offer opposed maternal afterlives: a kenotic motherhood that joins the abandoned, and a possessive motherhood that takes the child with it into death. Edith's mother belongs to the first type. The corpus thus extends its central antithesis to the maternal. There is a Saturnine mother as there is a Saturnine father, and the difference between them is again the difference between giving the child a future and taking the child's future for oneself.



Chapter Six

The Marine Lover

The Shape of Water *and the Feminist Rewriting of the Beast-Bridegroom*

Whither thou goest, I will go; and where thou lodgest, I will lodge: thy people shall be my people.

Ruth 1:16

6.1 *The Lineage of the Animal Bridegroom*

Apuleius's tale of Cupid and Psyche, embedded in the *Metamorphoses* (4.28–6.24), set the European paradigm of the animal bridegroom. An oracle declares that Psyche must marry a monster feared even by the gods; she lives with an invisible husband she is forbidden to see; her sisters persuade her that he is a serpent; she lights a lamp, discovers Cupid, and loses him when a drop of oil wakes him, regaining him only through trials that end in her apotheosis. The tale's central prohibition falls on the bride's gaze. Jeanne-Marie Leprince de Beaumont's "La Belle et la Bête" (1756), written as a moral lesson for girls, made the animal husband visible and taught that virtue should be preferred to beauty, rewarding Beauty's choice when the Beast becomes a prince. Marina Warner's *From the Beast to the Blonde* (1994) showed how such tales prepared girls for marriages arranged without regard to their desire. Jean Cocteau's *La Belle et la Bête* (1946) kept the transformation, and an often-repeated anecdote has Greta Garbo, at its final scene, asking for her beast back. Bruno Bettelheim's *The Uses of Enchantment* (1976) supplied the psychoanalytic rationale: the animal groom figures the child's disgust at sexuality, which the maturing girl must overcome until the beast is revealed as a man.

Feminist writers attacked Bettelheim's normalising reading, and Angela Carter's *The Bloody Chamber* (1979) answered it twice. In "The Courtship of Mr Lyon" the beast becomes a man in the traditional way. In "The Tiger's Bride" the heroine, lost by her father to the beast at cards, renounces the economy of exchange that made her a stake, and at the story's end the tiger's tongue strips away her skin to reveal the fur beneath. The woman becomes beast, and the metamorphosis frees her from her father's commodification. Del Toro has repeatedly objected to the convention that the beast must become handsome to be loved. *The Shape of Water* completes Carter's reversal: the creature never becomes a man, and it is the woman who is transformed.

6.2 *From the Black Lagoon to Baltimore: The Asset and the Open Veins*

Del Toro has recounted that, watching Jack Arnold's *Creature from the Black Lagoon* (1954) as a child, he wished the Gill-man and the heroine played by Julie Adams had ended up together, and that he later proposed to Universal a

version told from the creature's side. *The Shape of Water* (2017) is that version, displaced to Baltimore in 1962. Elisa Esposito, a mute cleaner at the Occam Aerospace Research Center, encounters an amphibious man captured in the Amazon, where, according to his captor Colonel Richard Strickland, the local people worshipped him as a god. The laboratory calls him "the Asset". The military hopes his capacity to breathe in two environments will advantage the United States in the space race, and when that hope fades General Hoyt orders him killed and dissected before the Soviets can study him.

The plot condenses the history Eduardo Galeano told in *Las venas abiertas de América Latina* (1971): a continent whose silver was mined by Indigenous people conscripted under the colonial mita, whose sugar was cut by enslaved Africans, and whose rubber was tapped by Amazonian peoples held in debt bondage and terrorised by company overseers, as Roger Casement reported to the British government from the Putumayo in 1912, all of it flowing outward to the metropoles. A god of the Amazon becomes a strategic resource of the North, his blood drawn for analysis in a Baltimore laboratory. Strickland articulates the Saturnine theology that underwrites the extraction. He tells Zelda that the creature cannot bear God's image, since the Lord is human in form, and adds that the Lord perhaps looks more like him than like her: the *imago Dei* is claimed as white and male. Strickland reads Norman Vincent Peale's *The Power of Positive Thinking* (1952), buys a teal Cadillac, and inhabits a world whose palette, like that of the laboratory and of the advertisements Giles paints, is saturated with the greens and teals del Toro associates with a manufactured future, while red is reserved for love and cinema. His body rots beneath its hygiene (Chapter One). When the creature, shot on the dock, heals himself and turns on him, Strickland's last words are that he is a god. The colonial imagination recognises the divinity it captured only as that divinity kills it.

6.3 *Innsmouth Redeemed: The Wound as Organ*

Elisa's surname is the one traditionally given to foundlings in Naples, from *esposto*, exposed. She is the abandoned child of the Roman prodigy rite (Chapter Three), found as an infant in a river with three parallel scars on each side of her neck and presumed to have lost her voice to the violence that left them. The climax returns her to the water. Shot by Strickland at the canal, she is carried into the harbour by the creature, and beneath the surface her scars

open as gills and she breathes. The wound is revealed as an organ: what had been read as the mark of an early injury, and of the impairment that followed it, is disclosed as a capacity for another element. Lovecraft's narrator discovers his amphibious descent as damnation; Elisa discovers hers as grace. And the myth with which this dissertation began is fulfilled. Xolotl, who refused to die for the movement of the sun, fled into the water and became the axolotl; Elisa, shot by the agent of a sacrificial order, escapes death by entering the water and becoming amphibious. The amphibium is the being that survives sacrifice by passing into a second world.

Disability studies has raised a serious objection to this ending. Some critics argued that it links Elisa's impairment to nonhumanity, implying that a disabled woman's fulfilment lies outside human society and with a nonhuman partner, and that the gills retroactively make her disability a sign she never fully belonged. The objection is weighty, and the film's answer is partial. It never cures Elisa: she does not speak, except in one imagined musical number in which she sings to the creature, and her language throughout is sign, which the film presents as complete. Her silence also has a politics. Josefina Ludmer's "Tretas del débil" (1984) read Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz's *Respuesta a Sor Filotea* (1691), the great baroque defence of a woman's right to learning, as a repertoire of the tricks of the weak: professing ignorance, speaking from an assigned place, making silence a space of resistance. Under pressure from the church hierarchy (above all, in Octavio Paz's influential account of 1982, from the archbishop of Mexico, Francisco de Aguiar y Seijas, and her confessor, Antonio Núñez de Miranda), Sor Juana eventually gave up her library and her studies and signed a profession of faith, reportedly in her own blood. Elisa's sign language is a *treta* in Ludmer's sense. She signs an obscenity at Strickland that he cannot read, and Zelda translates it into deference. Silence in del Toro is not lack but a language the powerful cannot hear.

6.4 *Desire Without Lack*

The film's philosophical centre is a sentence Elisa signs to Giles when he refuses to help her free the creature. When the creature looks at her, she explains, he does not know what she lacks or how she is incomplete; he sees her as she is. The sentence is a theory of desire. For Lacan, desire is constituted by lack, and the phallus is the signifier of lack in a symbolic order that defines

woman by what she does not have. Irigaray's *This Sex Which Is Not One* (1977) contested that definition of feminine sexuality as absence, and Deleuze and Guattari's *Anti-Oedipus* (1972) redefined desire as production rather than lack. Elisa's sentence enacts both critiques in the idiom of recognition. The creature's gaze is the first she has met that does not measure her against a norm she fails; it sees neither a mute woman nor an orphan nor a cleaner, but a being.

The film reorganises the economy of looking accordingly. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) argued that classical cinema gives the active gaze to the male protagonist and "to-be-looked-at-ness" to the woman; *The Shape of Water* gives the look to Elisa and makes the creature's body, sculpted for beauty, the spectacle. Cixous proposed that the Medusa, looked at directly, is not deadly but beautiful and laughing; del Toro extends the proposal to the monstrous masculine. The film's sexual politics are equally exact. It opens with Elisa's morning routine, eggs boiling to a kitchen timer and a bath in which she masturbates, granting its heroine an autonomous sexuality before any romance. Strickland, by contrast, covers his wife's mouth during intercourse, and in his office he sexually harasses Elisa, a cleaner under his authority, telling her that her muteness arouses him. Saturnine desire is the desire to silence.

The flood completes the argument. Theweleit's soldier males feared the flood as the dissolution of their armoured bodies (Chapter One). Elisa seals her bathroom, fills it with water, and makes love to the creature in the submerged room; the water seeps through the floor into the Orpheum cinema below, which is showing *The Story of Ruth* (1960). Female desire, figured as fluid, floods the cinema, and the film on its screen tells of a Moabite woman who chose a foreign people as her own. Irigaray's essay on "the 'mechanics' of fluids" argued that Western rationality privileges solids over fluids as the patriarchal symbolic privileges the self-identical over the plural; her *Amante marine* (1980), from which this chapter takes its title, read Nietzsche's ambivalence toward the sea as fear of the feminine element. Strickland is solid mechanics. Elisa and the creature are a mechanics of fluids.

6.5 *The Coalition of the Unsayable and Its Limits*

The film assembles a coalition of the unsayable: a mute woman, the Black woman who works beside her, a closeted gay artist, a Soviet scientist who val-

ues the creature's life above both superpowers' interests, and the creature. Each is someone whose speech or existence 1962 America could not publicly accommodate. The film binds their exclusions in a single scene at a pie shop, where the counterman on whom Giles has a crush turns a Black couple away and, when Giles lays a hand on his, recoils in disgust and orders him out: homophobia and racism appear as one regime. It also registers the complicity of its own nostalgia. Giles, watching television, switches from news footage of civil rights protesters to an old musical, and the gesture names the evasion that cinematic escapism can perform.

The coalition's limits must be stated plainly. Zelda's interiority remains subordinate to Elisa's story; she returns at the end to the husband who betrayed her, and liberation through water is granted to Elisa alone. bell hooks's "Eating the Other" (1992) analysed the commodification of racial otherness as a resource through which white subjects seek renewal, and the film is not immune: the creature's people appear only as hearsay in his captor's mouth, and the history of colonial extraction is resolved through romance rather than restitution. The film's strongest defence is its insistence on the creature's agency and on mutuality: he chooses Elisa, heals her, and kills the man who would kill them both. It also undercuts its romance deliberately through the cat problem (Chapter Three). Del Toro's xenophilia is strongest where it refuses to idealise.

6.6 *Apophatic Romance*

The film closes with Giles reciting lines adapted from a poem attributed to the twelfth-century Persian poet Sana'i, in which the beloved, whose shape cannot be perceived, is found everywhere. In the Sufi tradition from which the lines come, human love (*'ishq*) is both figure and path for the love of a God who exceeds every form. The title names the same paradox: water has no shape of its own and takes the shape of what holds it. *The Shape of Water* is an apophatic romance, a love story conducted in the grammar of negative theology, in which, as in the *Mystical Theology* of Pseudo-Dionysius, the divine is approached by negating every attribute that would fix it. The creature heals: he restores Giles's hair and closes the wound he had inflicted on Giles's arm, he revives himself after being shot, and he returns Elisa to life. He is Isaiah's suffering servant and the Sufi's shapeless beloved at once, and the film fuses

Franciscan creatureliness (Chapter Two) with Sufi mysticism. Levinas's caress, which solicits what escapes its form (Chapter One), finds here its fullest cinematic realisation. To love the creature is to love what cannot be grasped, and the film's ethics of touch culminates in an embrace beneath the water, where no hand can close around anything.



Chapter Seven

Prometheus Forgiven

Frankenstein (*2025*) *as Summa*

Did I request thee, Maker, from my clay
To mould me Man?

Milton, *Paradise Lost* 10.743–44; epigraph to *Frankenstein*, 1818

7.1 *One Storm, Two Myths: The Summer of 1816*

The two myths that organise del Toro's corpus were born in the same house in the same season. In June 1816, during the "year without a summer" that followed the eruption of Mount Tambora, Lord Byron, Percy Bysshe Shelley, Mary Godwin, Claire Clairmont, and John Polidori were confined by storms to the Villa Diodati on Lake Geneva, and Byron proposed that each write a ghost story. Mary Godwin's contribution became *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818). Polidori's became "The Vampyre" (1819), whose aristocratic predator, Lord Ruthven, modelled on Byron, inaugurated the modern vampire from which *Cronos*, *Blade II*, and *The Strain* descend. Byron himself wrote "Prometheus" that July, praising the Titan whose godlike crime was to be kind. The creature that cannot die and the predator that will not die are siblings of a single storm, and del Toro's career may be described as an inquiry into which of them the modern world would choose to be.

Del Toro has called *Frankenstein* his favourite novel and described his childhood encounter with Boris Karloff in religious terms: raised Catholic and unable to understand the saints, he understood on seeing Karloff what a saint or a messiah looked like (Wiseman 2025). As early as 2007 he spoke of wanting to make a "Miltonian tragedy" of the novel. The film he finally released in 2025 is the summa of the corpus in the scholastic sense: a work that gathers every prior question and answers it in a single architecture.

7.2 *The Monster's Mother: Feminist Readings of Shelley*

Feminist criticism transformed the reading of Shelley's novel by restoring its author's body to it. Mary Wollstonecraft, whose *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) founded modern liberal feminism, died of puerperal fever eleven days after giving birth to her daughter in 1797. In March 1815 the seventeen-year-old Mary recorded in her journal that she had dreamed her dead infant had come back to life, that it had only been cold, and that they had rubbed it before the fire and it lived. Ellen Moers (1976) read *Frankenstein* as a birth myth rooted in that experience of maternity and infant death; Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar (1979) read the creature as a disguised Eve, a figure for female deformity and exclusion; Anne K. Mellor (1988) read Victor's

project as a masculine science that usurps female reproduction and then abandons its offspring; Barbara Johnson's "My Monster/My Self" (1982) read the novel as an autobiography of female authorship as monstrosity. Shelley herself, in the introduction of 1831, called the book her "hideous progeny".

The Promethean myth already carried a misogynist corollary. In Hesiod, Zeus punishes Prometheus's theft of fire by creating Pandora, the first woman, a beautiful evil sent to men. Shelley's Victor reverses and repeats the logic. Asked by the creature for a companion, he begins to build one and then tears her apart, fearing among other things that she might refuse to comply with a compact made before her creation: the female creature is destroyed because she might have a will of her own. James Whale's *Bride of Frankenstein* (1935) gave that will its most famous image when the Bride, newly animated, recoils from her intended mate with a hiss, and Whale cast the same actress, Elsa Lanchester, as the Bride and as Mary Shelley in the prologue. The author and the refusing woman share a face.

7.3 *Mother, Father, Patron: Del Toro's Revisions*

Del Toro's film relocates Shelley's birth myth into Victor's childhood and doubles it. Victor's mother, Claire, dies giving birth to his brother William, and Victor's obsession with abolishing death begins as grief for her. Mia Goth plays both Claire and Elizabeth, so that the doubling Whale used to bind author to Bride binds mother to beloved. Victor's desire for Elizabeth, who is engaged to William and declines Victor's advances, is thus marked from the start as the desire to recover the mother whom birth took from him. His father, Leopold, a renowned surgeon, disciplines him with blows during anatomy lessons, and the film makes the transmission of that pedagogy explicit: when the newly animated Creature learns slowly and can say only one word, "Victor", Victor begins to imitate his father's cruelty. Alice Miller's poisonous pedagogy (Chapter Four) is shown in the act of reproducing itself across a generation.

The film's most consequential addition is a patron. Expelled from the Royal College of Surgeons of Edinburgh for reanimating corpses, an act its tribunal condemns as sacrilege, Victor is financed by Henrich Harlander, an arms merchant and Elizabeth's uncle, who offers money and an isolated tower on one unnamed condition. Victor assembles the Creature from the bodies of executed criminals and of soldiers killed in the Crimean War. The political economy is

exact. A munitions magnate funds the reanimation of the bodies his trade has destroyed, and the Creature is literally composed of the war's dead, Owen's half the seed of Europe (Chapter Four) restitched into one body. Harlander's condition, revealed on the night of the experiment, is that he is dying of syphilis and wants his brain transplanted into the new body. He is the capitalist immortal of Chapter One in his purest form: a man who would occupy the body made from the dead of his wars. When Victor refuses, Harlander tries to sabotage the experiment and falls to his death. Franco Moretti's thesis that Dracula and Frankenstein's creature represent capital and labour (Chapter One) is here enacted within a single plot, in which capital attempts to possess labour's reassembled body.

7.4 *Femicide Relocated*

Shelley's novel kills its women through the creature or through the law. The creature strangles Elizabeth on her wedding night; Justine Moritz, the servant falsely accused of William's murder, is executed while Victor stays silent; and the female creature is destroyed by her maker before she lives. Del Toro removes Justine entirely and has Victor refuse outright to make a companion, fearing that the Creature might reproduce. He then relocates the novel's central femicide. The Creature confronts Victor at William and Elizabeth's wedding; Elizabeth, hearing the struggle, runs to the Creature and embraces him; and Victor, firing at the Creature, shoots her. William is mortally wounded rushing the Creature and dies calling his brother a monster. The Creature carries Elizabeth to a cave and comforts her as she dies.

The revision completes a movement this dissertation has traced from the beginning. The violence against women that tradition attributed to the monster is assigned to the maker, and the monster becomes the one who holds the dying woman. The film also redistributes guilt through a lie: Victor tells William and Elizabeth that the Creature killed Harlander, and the creature is scapegoated, in Girard's precise sense (Chapter Two), for a death his maker's patron brought on himself. Elizabeth, who taught the Creature to say her name, is the figure of recognition that Elisa embodies in *The Shape of Water*. The Creature's first two words are "Victor" and "Elizabeth": the name of the father who made him and the name of the woman who recognised him, patronymic and elective kinship side by side.

7.5 *The Creature's Tale: The Pedagogy of the Blind*

The film's second part gives the Creature his own narration, structurally enacting the Girardian reversal in which the victim's account corrects the persecutor's. Escaping the tower that Victor, having blamed him for Harlander's death, set on fire with him inside, the Creature shelters among the gears of a farm's mill, inhabiting clockwork rather than being driven by it. He secretly supplies the family with firewood and builds a pen for their sheep, and they thank him as the Spirit of the Forest. While the family is away, he befriends their blind patriarch, who teaches him to read and to speak fluently. The blind teacher who perceives the Creature without seeing his body is Levinas's face in its most literal form: an encounter in which the other is met as a voice and a presence rather than as an object of vision. When the Creature returns to find his friend attacked by wolves, he drives them off and holds the dying man, and the family, returning, assumes he is the killer and shoots him.

He revives, and the revival is the film's metaphysical turn. The Creature discovers that he cannot die and must spend eternity alone. He later tries to destroy himself with dynamite in the Arctic and fails. Swift's Struldbruggs in *Gulliver's Travels* (1726) are the classical image of immortality as curse, and the Creature belongs to their line. But the corpus supplies a sharper contrast. *Cronos* began with a man offered immortality at the price of others' blood who chose to die rather than drink. *Frankenstein* ends with a being who has immortality without having sought it and cannot choose death. His kenosis must therefore take another form. Unable to renounce his life, he renounces his vengeance.

7.6 *From* The Modern Prometheus *to* Prometheus Unbound

Mary Shelley's novel is a tragedy of irresponsibility and retaliation: the creator abandons the creature, the creature destroys the creator's world, and both perish in the ice. Percy Shelley's lyrical drama *Prometheus Unbound* (1820) imagines the alternative. Its Prometheus, chained by Jupiter, recalls the curse he once pronounced on his tormentor, declaring that he repents and wishes no living thing to suffer pain; the revocation of hatred, not the defeat of the tyrant in combat, is the precondition of liberation. Shelley's preface rejects the reconciliation of champion and oppressor that he found in Aeschylus, and the dis-

tinction matters: Prometheus does not submit to Jupiter, he ceases to reproduce Jupiter's hatred. The drama closes with Demogorgon's charge to forgive wrongs darker than death or night and to defy power that seems omnipotent.

Del Toro's ending moves from Mary's Prometheus to Percy's. In the Arctic, the dying Victor and the Creature reconcile and address each other at last as father and son, and Victor dies. The Creature then frees the trapped ship from the ice, and Captain Anderson, unlike Walton in the novel, chooses to abandon his expedition and take his crew home. Alone, the Creature reaches out to embrace the sunlight, as Victor once taught him to do. The image recalls Nyssa in *Blade II*, who asked to die in the dawn (Chapter Two), but inverts it: the light that destroys the vampire is, for the Creature, an inheritance from the father who taught him to love it. The theogonic cycle of Chapter One, in which Ouranos is overthrown by Kronos and Kronos by Zeus, is broken. Leopold's cruelty passed to Victor; Victor's to the Creature; and the Creature, who could avenge, forgives. Del Toro has said that his approach to the material evolved with his own understanding of forgiveness. The son ends the cycle not by surpassing the father but by declining to become him.

7.7 Frankenstein *as Summa*

The film gathers the corpus. Its Saturns are three: the father who disciplines (Leopold), the patron who would live on in another's body (Harlander), and the maker who abandons his creation (Victor). Its clockwork is inhabited and repurposed by the Creature in the mill. Its Eucharist is inverted and then restored: a body assembled from the dead, raised against its will, that gives life (the firewood, the sheep pen, the ship) rather than taking it. Its amphibium is the oldest in literature, a being between death and life. Its disobedience runs in both directions, Victor's refusal of Harlander and the Creature's refusal of revenge. Its ghost is the dead mother whose face Victor seeks in Elizabeth, and its elective kin are the blind teacher and the woman who taught the Creature her name. Even the maker is changed in body: the explosion of the tower takes Victor's leg, and he ends his life with a prosthesis, partly made, as his creature was.

The arc of the whole oeuvre closes here. It opens in 1993 with Jesús Gris, who refuses to drink his granddaughter's blood and chooses death over a purchased eternity. It closes in 2025 with a creature who cannot die and refuses to

avenge himself. The first refusal is the renunciation of chronophagy by a man tempted to become Saturn; the second is the interruption of chronophagy's inheritance by a son who has every reason to repeat it. Between them lies the entire moral grammar of teratological humanism: the refusal to consume the time of others, whether by taking their blood or by returning their violence.



Chapter Eight

Drift and Kin

Hellboy, Pacific Rim, *and the Amphibious Commons*

For ye have not received the spirit of bondage again to fear; but ye have received the Spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, Abba, Father.

Romans 8:15

8.1 *Adoption Against Begetting*

The corpus contains a theory of paternity that criticism has not named. Its Saturnine fathers beget: Vidal wants a son to inherit his name and his watch; the Podestà drills the son he fathered for war; Leopold Frankenstein beats the son who will inherit his profession; Damaskinos breeds his son Nomak as the prototype of a superior strain. Its kenotic fathers adopt. Professor Broom raises an infant demon delivered by a Nazi rite; Stacker Pentecost lifts an orphan from the ruins of Tokyo; Dr. Casares directs an orphanage for the children of the Republic's dead; Geppetto, whose begotten son is killed in the war, must learn to love the son he carved as that son and not as Carlo's replacement; the blind man of *Frankenstein* takes an unknown giant as his pupil. Even Victor's last word to his creature, "son", is an act of adoption: the recognition, in speech, of a kinship that making alone had failed to establish. In del Toro, paternity is redeemed only as adoption.

The theological ground of this claim is Pauline. Paul describes the believer's relation to God as *huiothesia*, sonship by adoption (Romans 8:15; Galatians 4:5), rather than natural descent; the Christian is the adopted child of a father known by the cry "Abba" and not by blood. Anthropology reached a parallel conclusion by another road. David Schneider's *A Critique of the Study of Kinship* (1984) argued that the discipline had mistaken a Euro-American cultural symbol, shared blood, for a universal fact; Kath Weston's *Families We Choose* (1991) documented the kinship that lesbian and gay communities built beyond the biological family; Marshall Sahlins's *What Kinship Is—And Is Not* (2013) defined kinship as "mutuality of being", the condition of persons who participate intrinsically in each other's existence. Haraway's injunction to "make kin" in *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) extends the concept across species. Del Toro's adoptive families are mutualities of being in Sahlins's sense, and *Pacific Rim*, as we shall see, converts Sahlins's definition into a machine.

8.2 Hellboy*: The Unfaithful Offspring*

Hellboy (2004), adapted from Mike Mignola's comics, opens in 1944 on a Scottish island where Grigori Rasputin, in league with Nazi occultists, opens a portal in an operation named after the Norse twilight of the gods. What comes

through is not an army but an infant demon with a stone right hand, whom the young researcher Trevor Broom coaxes out of hiding with a candy bar and raises as his son. The sequence condenses the corpus's politics of birth. A fascist rite of apocalypse, drawn from the occult Nazism that Nicholas Goodrick-Clarke (1985) traced to the Ariosophists and the Thule Society, begets a child; a Catholic scholar adopts him; and the child grows up unfaithful to his origin. Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) described the cyborg as the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism and observed that such offspring are often "exceedingly unfaithful to their origins". Hellboy is the case in its purest form.

His body carries his destiny. The stone Right Hand of Doom is the key that would release the Ogdru Jahad, seven gods of chaos imprisoned beyond the stars, and his horns, which he files to stumps in the effort to pass among humans, mark him as the beast of a foretold apocalypse. At the climax Rasputin addresses him by his demonic name, Anung Un Rama; the horns grow out, a crown of fire ignites above his head, and the key begins to turn. Agent Myers recalls him to the father who raised him, and Broom's rosary, tossed to him across the chamber, completes the recall. Hellboy breaks off his own horn and impales Rasputin with it. The organ of his predestination becomes the instrument of his refusal. Pico's freedom to shape oneself (Chapter Three) is here neither presupposed nor bestowed; it is wrested from a destiny by a creature whose origin was engineered for apocalypse.

The film distributes amphibious traits across the family of the Bureau for Paranormal Research and Defense. Abe Sapien, an amphibious man discovered in a sealed chamber beside a note dated 14 April 1865, the day Lincoln was shot, knows by touch: laying his hands on an object he reads its history, and on a person, their mind. He is the positive counterpart of the Pale Man (Chapter One), a creature whose knowing hand receives rather than seizes. Liz Sherman, a pyrokinetic who has committed herself to a psychiatric institution for fear of a fire she cannot always control, is a woman who learns to direct her own power. She is the corpus's female Prometheus, a bearer of fire who decides where it falls: she incinerates the brood of the multiplying hound Sammael in the first film and melts the crown of the Golden Army in the second. When Rasputin draws Liz's soul from her body, Hellboy calls her back by whispering to whatever holds her on the other side that for her he would cross over, a threat issued to death itself on behalf of the beloved.

The Bureau is nonetheless ambivalent. It shelters monsters and conceals them; it employs them as weapons and treats their visibility as a security risk, so that it is at once refuge and container, an amphibious commons administered by the state. Hellboy's repeated escapes to watch over Liz, and his hunger to be seen, are protests against that containment, and the sequel brings the protest to a crisis.

8.3 Hellboy II: *The Prince, the Sister, and the Angel*

Hellboy II: The Golden Army (2008) opens with a bedtime story. On Christmas Eve 1955, Broom reads the young Hellboy the legend of an ancient war between humans and the hidden peoples, in which a goblin smith offered the elven king Balor an army of mechanical gold soldiers that could not be destroyed. Urged by his son, Prince Nuada, Balor accepted; appalled by the slaughter that followed, he made a truce with humanity, the forests for the hidden peoples and the cities for humans, and divided the crown that commands the army into three pieces, one of them entrusted to humans. Nuada refused the truce and went into exile. In the present he returns, kills his father, and hunts the pieces of the crown in order to wake the army and exterminate humankind.

Nuada is the corpus's most serious antagonist because his grievance is just. Humans have broken the truce in deed if not in word, devouring the forests for, as he says, parking lots and shopping malls. His indictment is ecological, and del Toro plainly shares it. His means, however, are Saturnine: patricide, an indestructible clockwork legion that was his own counsel from the beginning, and the extermination of a species. Luke Goss, who played Nomak in *Blade II*, plays Nuada as the second of del Toro's patricidal princes, and the doubling clarifies the corpus's position on revolt. Frantz Fanon's *Les Damnés de la terre* (1961) defended anticolonial violence as the colonised subject's self-creation; Camus's *L'Homme révolté* (Chapter Four) insisted that revolt betrays itself when it ceases to recognise a limit. Del Toro's sympathy runs to Nuada's cause and his judgment to Camus's limit. The rebel who answers chronophagy with extermination has become what he fights.

Nuada's appeal to Hellboy completes the argument. Having loosed the last forest god on New York, he asks why Hellboy fights for humans who have driven his kind into hiding and will never accept him. Hellboy kills the god,

which dies into a garden of moss and blossom spreading over the street, and the crowd he has just saved meets him with fear and abuse. The scene poses the political question of the amphibium in its starkest form: whose side is the being of two worlds on? The film refuses both answers on offer. In the chamber of the Golden Army, Hellboy invokes his descent from the royal house of Hell to claim the right to challenge Nuada for command, turning the infernal lineage he refused in the first film into the legal instrument by which he halts the army. He wins the duel and spares Nuada's life; when Nuada tries to kill him from behind, his twin sister Nuala, bound to him so that each bears the other's wounds, ends the threat by driving a blade into her own heart. The dying Nuada tells Hellboy that he too will one day have to choose which world must die. Abe, who has loved Nuala through the touch that lets them share minds, watches both twins turn to stone. Nuala completes the typology of sisters traced in Chapter Five: the sister who protects (Mercedes), the sister who possesses (Lucille), and the sister who sacrifices herself to end her brother's violence.

The film's most metaphysically charged scene precedes the battle. Mortally wounded, Hellboy is carried to the Angel of Death, a creature whose eyes stud its wings in the manner of the cherubim of Ezekiel 10:12, whose wings are "full of eyes". The design answers the Pale Man: his eyes sit in the palms that seize, the Angel's in the wings that enfold. The Angel tells Liz that Hellboy is destined to bring about the world's destruction and that she will suffer most if he lives; Liz chooses his life. Derrida's *The Gift of Death* holds that every responsibility to a singular other sacrifices all the others, and Liz assumes that aporia openly, rejecting the utilitarian sacrifice of the one for the many; the Conclusion will connect her choice to Ivan Karamazov's refusal of a harmony bought with a child's tears. The choice is also natal. Liz is pregnant with twins, and in choosing Hellboy she chooses a future that would otherwise be foreclosed. At the film's end Hellboy, Liz, and Abe walk away from the Bureau: an exodus from the state's container into an unaffiliated life whose future is a demon's and a pyrokinetic's children.

8.4 Pacific Rim*: Leviathan, the Wall, and the Drift*

Pacific Rim (2013) reverses the direction of Lovecraftian immensity. Colossal creatures, the kaiju, rise from an interdimensional fissure on the floor of the

Pacific and lay waste to coastal cities; humanity answers with the Jaegers, giant machines whose name means "hunter". The monsters are Leviathans in the biblical sense, creatures of the deep whom no human weapon can master (Job 41), and the machines raise the question Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) posed through its famous frontispiece: how can many bodies compose one? Hobbes answered with the sovereign, a single artificial person in whom the multitude's wills are surrendered and unified. *Pacific Rim* answers differently. A Jaeger's neural load is too great for one mind, so each machine is piloted by two persons linked through an interface called the Drift, in which memories and movements are shared without either will being surrendered. The Jaeger is an anti-Leviathan: a giant body animated not by a sovereign but by a partnership that remains two. Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) located the condition of political life in plurality, the fact that men, not Man, inhabit the earth; the Drift is plurality incarnated in steel.

The film is precise about the Drift's danger. Pilots who lose themselves in a partner's memories are said to be "chasing the rabbit", and when Mako Mori first drifts with Raleigh Becket she relives the attack on Tokyo that orphaned her, a small girl in an empty street clutching a single red shoe, and nearly discharges the Jaeger's plasma cannon inside the hangar. Raleigh enters her memory as a witness, not an owner. Edith Stein's *Zum Problem der Einfühlung* (1917) drew the distinction the Drift requires: empathy is the experience of another's experience as the other's, given to me without becoming mine, and must not be confused with fusion. Stein, a phenomenologist who lectured on the vocation of women, converted to Catholicism, and entered the Carmel, was arrested by the SS in the Netherlands in August 1942, together with other Catholics of Jewish descent, in reprisal for the Dutch bishops' public protest against the deportation of the Jews, and was gassed at Auschwitz-Birkenau on 9 August 1942. Her theory of empathy is the philosophical antidote to the genocide that killed her, and the Drift is its cinematic figure: two minds sharing one body while remaining distinct.

The Drift is also a theory of kinship. Its pilots are brothers, a father and son, a married couple, and triplets; compatibility is tested in combat, and Raleigh and Mako discover theirs in a duel with staffs, matched by rhythm rather than by blood, rank, or nation. The machine literalises Sahlins's mutuality of being. Mako's arc is the film's centre. Her adoptive father, Stacker Pentecost, the pilot who rescued her from the ruins, first grounds her for fear of losing her and

then lets her go, and he dies detonating a bomb to clear the way for her mission after announcing that the day's task is to cancel the apocalypse. In 2013 viewers proposed a "Mako Mori test" for films, asking whether a woman has a narrative arc that does not exist to support a man's story; the criterion's name records the film's departure from convention. Its last image confirms it. Surfacing from the sealed Breach, Raleigh and Mako embrace, foreheads touching, and do not kiss: partnership is not resolved into romance, and the haptic ethics of Chapter One finds its most egalitarian form.

The film's politics extend beyond the cockpit. As the kaiju grow, governments defund the Jaegers and build a coastal "Wall of Life", which a kaiju breaches within an hour. The walls fail where the Drift succeeds. It is difficult not to read the episode, from a Mexican director seven years after the Secure Fence Act of 2006 authorised hundreds of miles of barrier along the U.S.–Mexican border, through Anzaldúa's description of that border as *una herida abierta*, an open wound. The enemy, moreover, is a colonial power. When the biologist Newton Geiszler drifts with a fragment of kaiju brain, he learns that the creatures are cloned weapons bred by unseen masters, called the Precursors in the film's supporting materials, who attempted the planet once before, in the age of the dinosaurs, and have returned because human pollution has, in his words, practically terraformed it for them. Humanity's extractive economy has been preparing the earth for its invaders. Galeano's open veins (Chapter Six) become the planet's, and chronophagy reaches planetary scale. The black-market dealer Hannibal Chau, who sells kaiju organs as medicine, completes the economy of the carnival (Chapter Five); swallowed by a newborn kaiju and cutting his way out after the credits, he asks for his missing shoe, del Toro's self-parody of his most persistent motif.

8.5 *The Amphibious Commons and the Two Re-Enchantments*

The films of this chapter supply the social form the preceding chapters required. I call it the amphibious commons and define it by four features. Membership is elective, founded on shared vulnerability rather than shared blood, name, nation, or species. The threshold is held open: the commons admits what the wall excludes. Knowledge within it is haptic rather than grasping, a matter of touch, drift, and witness. And the future is permitted to arrive: in Liz's twins, in Ofelia's brother carried out of the labyrinth, in the son

Mercedes will raise without his father's name. The corpus contains a gallery of such commons and their counterfeits. Casares's orphanage, the Bureau, the Shatterdome, Giles's apartment above the Orpheum, and the blind man's cottage are commons, each fragile and each besieged. Allerdale Hall, the Occam laboratory, and the carnival of *Nightmare Alley* are counterfeits that borrow the language of family, science, or fellowship to organise consumption.

Silvia Federici's *Re-enchanting the World* (2018) argues that the commons is a set of social relations through which life is reproduced cooperatively, and that rebuilding such relations is the condition of escaping capital's enclosures. Her title answers Max Weber's diagnosis, in *Wissenschaft als Beruf* (1919), that modernity is fated to the disenchantment of the world. Del Toro's fantastic is a re-enchantment in Federici's sense, and *Hellboy* shows why the qualification matters. Its villains are themselves re-enchanters: the occult Nazism of the Thule circle, the undying Rasputin, the Norse apocalypse. Fascism, as Goodrick-Clarke and Jeffrey Herf's *Reactionary Modernism* (1984) showed in different ways, re-enchanted modernity with blood, soil, and myth while embracing its technology. *Hellboy* stages a war between two re-enchantments: one that sacralises lineage, destiny, and the end of the world, and one that sacralises the creature, the adopted child, and the ordinary continuation of time. The first wants the apocalypse; the second, in Pentecost's phrase, cancels it.

Saturn's last form now comes into view. The chronophage who cannot possess the future prefers that it not arrive at all. Rasputin opens the gates to the gods of chaos; Nuada wakes the deathless army; the colonisers of *Pacific Rim* clear the planet of its tenants; the Master of *The Strain* reduces the human race to livestock farmed for blood. Apocalypse is chronophagy's eschatology, the final consumption of time by those who refuse to share it. Del Toro's heroes oppose it not with a counter-apocalypse but with the defence of succession: a child carried out of the labyrinth, twins in a womb, a ship freed from the ice and sent home. Benjamin, in notes for his theses on history, suggested that revolutions might be less the locomotive of history than an attempt by its passengers to pull the emergency brake. The amphibious commons is that brake.



Conclusion

The Amphibious Imperative

Toward a Teratological Humanism

For unto us a child is born, unto us a son is given.

Isaiah 9:6

I. *One Argument*

The eight chapters of this dissertation have read del Toro's corpus as a single argument conducted across genres, languages, and three decades. Chapter One identified its adversary, chronophagy, and anatomised its fathers, capitalists, Prometheans, and sisters, its clockwork and its grasping hand. Chapter Two showed that the corpus answers chronophagy with a creaturely Catholicism whose central act is kenosis, the gift of one's own life rather than the taking of another's. Chapter Three constructed the ontology of the amphibium, the being of divided worlds whose dignity lies in remaining unfinished. Chapter Four traced an ethics of disobedience through a triptych that moves from ghost to martyr to survivor. Chapter Five read the corpus's ghosts as witnesses and its houses as archives of violence. Chapter Six read *The Shape of Water* as a theory of desire without lack. Chapter Seven read *Frankenstein* as the summa in which forgiveness breaks the theogonic cycle. Chapter Eight found in adoption and the Drift the social form of the whole, the amphibious commons. It remains to show why these are one argument rather than eight, and to state the maxim into which they condense.

II. *Natality Is Teratological*

The unifying insight is that del Toro's two great subjects, the monster and the child, are one subject seen from opposite sides of time. Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) rooted the capacity for action in natality, the fact that human beings are born and that each birth brings into the world a beginning nothing before it could have predicted. She called natality the miracle that saves the world from its natural ruin, and found the faith and hope proper to it in the glad tidings that a child has been born unto us, words that echo the verse of Isaiah standing above this Conclusion. Adriana Cavarero's *Nonostante Platone* (1990) turned the claim into a feminist critique of philosophy itself. Where Plato's *Phaedo* defined philosophy as the practice of dying, and Heidegger's *Sein und Zeit* (1927) defined authentic existence as being-toward-death, Cavarero recovered a thought oriented toward birth and toward the mothers the canon had silenced. Jacques Derrida supplied the third term. In the exergue to *De la grammatologie* (1967) he argued that the future can be

anticipated only as an absolute danger, because it breaks with constituted normality and can therefore be announced only as a kind of monstrosity; decades later he compressed the point into a sentence: "a future that would not be monstrous would not be a future" (Derrida 1995).

Joined, the three claims yield the thesis of this dissertation in its most compressed form: *natality is teratological*. Every birth is a *monstrum* in the oldest sense of the word, a showing and a sign that announces what was not foreseen. The Roman rites that sealed anomalous infants in chests and gave them to the sea (Chapter Three) were the institutional form of the terror of natality; Saturn's meal is its mythic form. He devours his children because the future arrives in them as a monster that would displace him. Chronophagy and teratophobia are therefore one act: to devour the future and to destroy the monster are the same refusal, the refusal of what comes after oneself. Del Toro's cinema reverses that refusal. Its children are monsters to the orders that would consume them, and its monsters are children those orders abandoned. The monster is the child the past refused; the child is the monster the future sends.

This is why a corpus so preoccupied with death remains free of the death-cult it diagnoses. It chooses neither Plato's practice of dying nor Saturn's flight from death. It accepts death as a sister, in Francis's phrase (Chapter Two), and welcomes birth in its monstrous form. Teratological humanism is a humanism of natality that consents to its own finitude. It lets itself be succeeded.

III. *The Amphibious Imperative*

Kant's *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten* (1785) states the categorical imperative in several formulations, which commentators commonly group under the headings of universal law, humanity, autonomy, and the kingdom of ends. The ethics this dissertation has reconstructed from del Toro's corpus can be stated as a single imperative with four formulations that answer Kant's, head by head. Its master formula is this:

Act so that your own finitude is never converted into the consumption of another's time, and so that the future, which arrives always as a child, a stranger, or a monster, is permitted to arrive.

The Formula of Finitude. *Live your mortality as your own: never purchase the extension of your life, your name, or your power with the lifetime of another.* The formula answers Kant's formula of universal law, and it passes a Kantian test that chronophagy fails. The chronophage's maxim, that I may preserve myself by consuming those who would succeed me, cannot be universalised without abolishing succession itself: a world in which every subject lived by devouring its successors would contain no successors, and therefore no time to devour. Kronos's reign demonstrates the contradiction, since it ends because one child is not eaten. Unamuno's hunger for immortality is permitted under this formula as longing and forbidden as appetite.

The Formula of the Creature. *Treat every creature, human or monstrous, in your own person or in that of any other, never merely as an asset, but always as a being whose time is its own, and approach it so as to touch without grasping.* The formula answers the formula of humanity and replaces Kant's "means" with the corpus's own word, "the Asset". It also resolves a tension Kant himself named. In the *Doctrine of Virtue* (1797, §24) he described love as a force that draws rational beings together and respect as a force that keeps them at a distance. The caress, which Levinas defined as a touch that seizes nothing (Chapter One), is the gesture in which the two forces coincide: nearness that does not possess. Marilyn Frye's *The Politics of Reality* (1983) named the opposite disposition the arrogant eye, which organises everything it sees with reference to itself; María Lugones's "Playfulness, 'World'-Travelling, and Loving Perception" (1987) opposed to it a loving perception that travels into the other's world. The Pale Man is the arrogant eye given a body, and Elisa's sentence, that the creature sees her as she is, is loving perception given a voice.

The Formula of Disobedience. *Refuse every command, whether of father, state, or god, whose fulfilment requires the sacrifice of another; give, if you must, what is yours to give, but never require of another what can only be given.* The formula answers the formula of autonomy and radicalises a position Kant had already taken against Abraham (Chapter Four). Its literary charter is Ivan Karamazov's rebellion in *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), where Ivan, imagining a final harmony purchased with the tears of a single tortured child, declines the harmony and respectfully returns his ticket. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) gave Ivan's refusal its modern parable: a city whose happiness depends on the misery of one child, and the citizens who,

having seen the child, walk away. Ofelia, asked to open the gate of a kingdom with her brother's blood, is the child who returns the ticket.

The Formula of the Commons. *Act as a member of a commons of creatures rather than as the subject of a kingdom: choose your kin by shared vulnerability rather than shared blood, and hold the in-between open for every being that cannot or will not complete the metamorphosis the world demands of it.* The formula answers Kant's kingdom of ends, and its change of noun is deliberate. A kingdom presupposes a sovereign and a line of succession; the residual monarchism of *Pan's Labyrinth* (Chapter Four) showed how easily even a utopia of disobedience reverts to the iconography of the throne. A commons presupposes neither. Its members are the adopted, the drifted, and the found, and its emblem is the axolotl, the creature that keeps its gills.

Kant's formulation	*Amphibious formulation*	*Saturnine violation*	*Exemplary refusal*	*Principal interlocutors*
Universal law	Finitude: never convert your mortality into another's consumption	Vidal's watch; de la Guardia's device; Harlander's bid for the Creature's body	Jesús Gris refuses Aurora's blood	Hesiod, Unamuno, Becker, Arendt
Humanity	The Creature: no being merely an asset; touch without grasping	"The Asset"; the geek; Volpe's contract; the Pale Man	Elisa's recognition; Abe's touch; the blind man's hospitality	Levinas, Frye, Lugones, Nussbaum
Autonomy	Disobedience: refuse commanded sacrifice; never require what can only be given	The Faun's demand; the Podestà's drill; Leopold's discipline	Ferreiro; Ofelia; Pinocchio; the Creature's forgiveness	Kant, Dostoevsky, Fromm, Arendt, Ahmed, Améry
Kingdom of ends	The Commons: kin by shared vulnerability; the in-between held open	Allerdale Hall; the Occam laboratory; the Wall of Life	The orphans; the Bureau's exodus; the Drift	Anzaldúa, Haraway, Federici, Sahlins, Weston

Read across, each row pairs a Kantian heading with its amphibious counterpart, the Saturnine act that counterpart forbids, the scene in which the corpus refuses that act, and the thinkers with whom this dissertation has read it.

IV. *The Asymmetry of the Gift*

The third formulation contains the principle that resolves the two hardest problems this dissertation has encountered. The first is Ofelia's death. Chapter Four found that the King's test retroactively demanded the blood Ofelia freely gave, so that the film's luminous ending risks sanctifying a girl's sacrifice. The asymmetry of the gift names exactly what is wrong. Kenosis may be offered; it may never be exacted. A life given by the vulnerable on behalf of the more vulnerable is the highest act the corpus knows, but a test designed to require that death is Abraham's command in a fairy-tale crown. The feminist critique of sacrificial atonement (Brown and Parker) and the corpus's own trajectory from *Pan's Labyrinth* to *Pinocchio* converge on this distinction.

The second problem is forgiveness. *Frankenstein* ends with an act of forgiveness that breaks the cycle of paternal violence, while the Spanish films insist that the dead must not be forgotten. Are these compatible? Arendt held that forgiveness is the only remedy for the irreversibility of action, the one response to injury that is not a mere reaction and that therefore frees both parties from the automatism of vengeance. Jean Améry, a member of the Belgian resistance whom the Gestapo tortured at the fort of Breendonk in 1943 and then deported to Auschwitz as a Jew, defended in *Jenseits von Schuld und Sühne* (1966) the victim's resentment as a moral protest against the social pressure to forgive and forget. Derrida's "On Forgiveness" (2001) argued that forgiveness forgives only the unforgivable and is corrupted when it becomes an instrument of political reconciliation. Spain's *pacto del olvido* (Chapter Four) was precisely such an instrument: forgetting decreed by the state and presented as reconciliation. Under the asymmetry of the gift these positions become consistent. Forgiveness belongs to the victim to give and never to the community to require; it does not erase memory, and memory may never be traded for peace. The Creature forgives because no one demands it of him. The ghosts of the cistern and the clay are owed remembrance, and no one may forgive on their behalf.

V. *Teratological Humanism and Its Neighbours*

Teratological humanism can now be situated among the positions from which it borrows and with which it contends. Against classical humanism, from Pico

to Kant, it denies that dignity is grounded in rational self-legislation and relocates it in natality, vulnerability, and the capacity to refuse chronophagy; yet it retains classical humanism's conviction that "human" names a dignity rather than merely a species. Against critical posthumanism, from Haraway to Braidotti and Wolfe, it shares the critique of species exceptionalism but declines to abandon the honorific, predicating humanity of demons, amphibians, puppets, and the reanimated dead. Martha Nussbaum's *Frontiers of Justice* (2006) identified three frontiers at which social-contract theory fails: disability, nationality, and species membership. *The Shape of Water* assembles its coalition at exactly those three frontiers, a mute woman, a foreign scientist and a colonised creature, and an animal god, and teratological humanism may be described as the effort to extend dignity across all three without dissolving the concept of the human that dignity requires.

Its closest neighbour is the feminist ethics of care, from Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) and Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984) to Joan Tronto's *Moral Boundaries* (1993) and Eva Feder Kittay's *Love's Labor* (1999). Kittay's insistence that each of us is "some mother's child", and that dependency is the universal human condition, is the anthropology del Toro's corpus presupposes. The present study adds to care ethics a political theology of time. Berenice Fisher and Joan Tronto (1990) defined care as "everything that we do to maintain, continue, and repair our 'world'"; care, so understood, is time given, and chronophagy is time taken. The opposition between them is the opposition between Elisa, who spends her night shifts cleaning the laboratory and her breaks feeding eggs to a captive god, and Strickland, who spends other people's time as if it were his own. Silvia Federici's *Wages Against Housework* (1975) supplies the economic correlate: the unwaged time of women's reproductive labour is a resource that capital consumes without paying for it, which is why Allerdale Hall and the Occam laboratory are, in the end, the same house.

Adriana Cavarero's *Inclinazioni* (2013) completes the comparison with an image. Western philosophy, she argues, has privileged the upright subject, vertical, self-contained, and erect, and has suppressed the posture of inclination, the body leaning toward another, of which the mother bending over her child is the paradigm. Del Toro's chronophages are figures of rectitude: Vidal's straight lines, Strickland's posture, Leopold's rigid frame. His heroes incline: Elisa leaning at the tank, Hellboy cradling a rescued infant, the Creature curv-

ing around the dying Elizabeth, the blind man stooping to teach. The armoured body of Chapter One and the inclined body of these scenes are the two postures of the human, and the corpus chooses inclination.

VI. *Limits*

Four limits must be acknowledged. The first is gendered. Del Toro's monsters are overwhelmingly male, and the work of recognising them falls overwhelmingly to women: Elisa, Elizabeth, Liz, Edith, Ofelia, Nuala. Several of those women die. The structure risks converting women into the moral infrastructure of male redemption, an emotional labour in Arlie Hochschild's sense (1983) performed on behalf of creatures whose stories remain at the centre. The corpus partly answers the objection through Mercedes, Susan Tyler, Mako Mori, and Edith Cushing, who survives her Gothic to write it; but teratological humanism is gendered in its distribution of labour even where it is feminist in its values. The second limit is appropriation. bell hooks's critique of "eating the Other" and the disability critique of *The Shape of Water* (Chapter Six) both warn that a cinema of sympathetic monsters can make the marginalised into screens for the majority's renewal. The cat problem is the corpus's best defence, and not a sufficient one.

The third limit concerns violence. The corpus admires Mercedes's knife and the Creature's forgiveness, and the asymmetry of the gift reconciles them only in part: defensive violence by the vulnerable is permitted, vengeance is never required, and forgiveness is never demanded, but no formula can say in advance where defence ends and vengeance begins. The fourth limit is industrial. A critique of chronophagic capital financed and distributed by Universal, Warner Bros., Fox Searchlight, and Netflix inhabits a contradiction it cannot resolve. Bolívar Echeverría's baroque ethos (Chapter Two) names the strategy of survival within it, and the handcrafted surface is its emblem: when *Frankenstein* won Academy Awards for costume design, makeup and hairstyling, and production design, it was honoured precisely for the work of the hand.

A final, methodological limit attends every claim in this study. The Amphibious Imperative is a reconstruction, not a doctrine del Toro has stated. Films think in images, and the translation of images into maxims is an interpretation that the images themselves remain free to contradict.

VII. *Coda: The Face at the Edge of the Sea*

Michel Foucault closed *Les Mots et les choses* (1966) with a prophecy: man, a recent invention of Western knowledge, might soon be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. This dissertation began with an amphibian and ends at that shoreline. Del Toro's corpus answers Foucault not by denying that the classical figure of man is passing, but by showing what becomes of the face at the water's edge. It does not vanish. It opens gills. Elisa's scars, read for a lifetime as the marks of an old wound, part beneath the surface and let her breathe; the Amphibian Man returns to the element from which he was stolen; Abe Sapien reads the world through his hands; the Creature, at the margin of the Arctic sea, stretches toward a sun his father taught him to love. Xolotl, who would not die so that the sun might move, fled into the lake and lent his name to an animal that never finishes becoming.

Above a street corner in Cambridge, a clockwork locust devours the seconds beneath the first clause of John's verse: the world passes away, and the lust thereof. The verse has a second clause, which promises that whoever does the will of God abides. In the idiom of this dissertation, the will that abides is the will that refuses to devour. Saturn eats the hours. The axolotl keeps its gills. Between them, at the edge of the sea, the human face does not disappear. It learns to breathe in two worlds.

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Keywords

Guillermo del Toro; teratological humanism; chronophagy; the Amphibious Imperative; amphibium; kenosis; kenotic disobedience; natality; asymmetry of the gift; monster theory; teratology; political theology; creaturely life; Saturn; Kronos; Mexican baroque; ex-voto*; Gothic cinema; female Gothic; hauntology; spectrality; counter-archive; historical memory; Spanish Civil War cinema;* pacto del olvido*; anti-fascism; disobedience; poisonous pedagogy; fairy-tale studies; beast-bridegroom; Frankenstein; Mary Shelley; Prometheus; Romanticism; vampirism; Lovecraft; cosmic horror; mimicry; mestizaje;* nepantla*; neoteny; axolotl; haptic ethics; the caress; adoption; elective kinship; the commons; re-enchantment; feminist film theory; feminist philosophy; ethics of care; vulnerability; grievability; disability studies; posthumanism; critical humanism; ecocriticism; forgiveness; Levinas; Arendt; Weil; Irigaray; Kristeva; Cixous; Cavarero; Haraway; Anzaldúa; Butler; Federici.*



Saturn eats the hours. The axolotl keeps its gills. Between them, at the edge of the sea, the human face does not disappear. It learns to breathe in two worlds.